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Consumer Relationship Development in High-Uncertainty Contexts

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Abstract

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Relational Exchange Theory (RET) is a foundational marketing theory explaining how relationships develop, with trust, commitment, and uncertainty as its core concepts. Since its development in the 1980s, initially for studying relationships in Business-to-Business (B2B) markets, its extension to Business-to-Consumer (B2C) markets has been widely debated and has also shaped contemporary research. However, RET has predominantly been developed and applied in low-uncertainty contexts, characterized by familiarity and reliable information cues. This focus has resulted in RET being grounded in contexts where familiarity and reliable information cues are readily available, thereby supporting the formation of trust and commitment.

These conditions, however, do not hold in high-uncertainty contexts, where outcomes cannot be readily anticipated due to ambiguous, limited, or absent information and familiarity cues. Such heightened and persistent uncertainty can impede trust and commitment, thereby constraining the development of consumer relationships. This calls for consideration of RET's applicability beyond the contexts in which it was originally developed. Addressing this issue is essential, as it not only contributes to the debate on RET's application in B2C markets but also extends its boundary conditions to high-uncertainty contexts. This overlooked theoretical puzzle defines the central problem addressed in this thesis. Therefore, *this thesis aims to study and increase understanding of consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts*.

This thesis uses small, unfamiliar, resource-constrained retailers adopting partial online internationalization (POI) in cross-border e-commerce (CBEC) as an empirical illustration of a high-uncertainty context for studying consumer relationship development. Using mixed methods, the thesis follows a multiphase research design. In the exploratory phase, a systematic review of the consumer CBEC literature was conducted (Paper I), showing, through bibliometric and content analyses, that consumers navigate multiple types of uncertainty and that the use of RET in this domain remains limited. Building on this, a survey was developed for two papers (Papers II and III) in the confirmatory phase to test RET in a high-uncertainty context, with each paper focusing on different types of uncertainty affecting the initial phase of consumer relationship development. As their findings deviated from RET, a qualitative study was conducted in the explicatory phase to understand the development of the relationship in depth (Paper IV). Collectively, these papers show that consumer relationship development follows a different path in high-uncertainty contexts than RET suggests.

This thesis contributes to the RET literature in three main ways. First, it develops a conceptual framework for consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts. In doing so, it refines and advances the explanatory scope of RET to account for these contexts. Second, it identifies the uncertainties consumers encounter and shows their effects throughout the relationship development, demonstrating that uncertainty shifts from reduction to ongoing coping as relationships develop. Third, it explains how consumers develop relationships, organized into three phases: initial, building, and relationship, each characterized by distinct roles of uncertainty, trust, and commitment.

Keywords: Relational Exchange Theory, B2C Relationship, Uncertainty, Trust, Commitment, Cross-Border E-commerce

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„Be šaknų medis neauga“

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Uppsala, March 2026
Ugnė

List of Papers

This thesis is based on the following papers, which are referred to in the text by their Roman numerals.

I. Wistedt, U., and Safari, A. (2026). A Literature Review of Consumer Behavior in Cross-Border E-commerce: A Conceptual Framework. Under Review in *European Journal of Marketing*.

II. Wistedt, U. (2024). Consumer Purchase Intention toward POI-retailers in Cross-Border E-commerce: An Integration of Technology Acceptance Model and Commitment-Trust Theory. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*, *81*, 104015.

III. Wistedt, U., and Safari, A. (2026). Exploring Purchase Intention in Cross-Border E-commerce: A Relational View. *International Marketing Review*, *43*(7), 50-83.

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1. Introduction

In the early 1900s, marketing began to take shape as a scientific discipline (Sheth et al., 2024). Marketing scholarship has since evolved into a substantial body of knowledge that continues to shape contemporary thought and remains vital to both scholars and practitioners (Madhavaram, 2024). At its core, exchange has long been recognized as central to marketing, as acknowledged by both the American Marketing Association (2026) and marketing scholars (Bagozzi, 1975; Hunt, 1976; Houston and Gassenheimer, 1987; Pels, 1999; Edvardsson et al., 2011; Madhavaram, 2024). Exchange has historically been theorized as transactional, with the seller being active and the buyer being passive (Grönroos, 1994; Rindfleisch, 2020). Within this transactional view, the seller actively initiates discrete exchanges using the marketing mix (i.e., 4Ps: Product, Price, Promotion, and Place), while the buyer passively responds to these activities (Palmer et al., 2005; Tronvoll and Edvardsson, 2024). However, in the 1980s, the marketing discipline experienced a paradigm shift that reshaped the theoretical foundations of exchange (Ford, 1980; Håkansson, 1982; Dwyer et al., 1987; Johanson and Mattsson, 1987). This shift redirected marketing thought from discrete, short-term transactions to long-term relationships that benefit both the seller and the buyer (Dwyer et al., 1987; Grönroos, 1994; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 2000; O'Malley, 2014). The tensions between these two schools of thought laid the theoretical foundation for contemporary marketing thought, which is grounded in two general foundational theories, namely Transactional Exchange Theory (TET) and Relational Exchange Theory (RET) (Gundlach and Murphy, 1993; Coviello and Brodie, 1998; Gruen, 1995; Li and Nicholls, 2000; Pels et al., 2000; Rao and Perry, 2002; Safari and Albaum, 2019; Steinhoff et al., 2019; Madhavaram, 2024).

Initially, relational exchange ideas were developed within interorganizational research to study Business-to-Business (B2B) relationships (e.g., Ford, 1980; Håkansson, 1982; Dwyer et al., 1987; Johanson and Mattsson, 1987; Edvardsson et al., 2008) and were later extended beyond these contexts. This extension marked a pivotal shift in the 1990s, when scholars began to rethink Business-to-Consumer (B2C) markets by moving from a transactional toward a relational perspective (Gruen, 1995; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Pels, 1999). This shift was not without criticism, as several scholars questioned the applicability and relevance of relational perspectives in B2C markets (Barnes, 1994; O'Malley and Tynan, 2000; Leahy, 2011). Since then, B2C relationships

have remained one of the most intensely debated subjects in the history of marketing scholarship (Wulf and Odekerken-Schröder, 2001; Steinhoff et al., 2019; Alvarez et al., 2023) and have expanded into related fields such as information systems (Jarvenpaa et al., 2000; Gefen et al., 2003; Pavlou et al., 2007; Campbell et al., 2013; Lin et al., 2023) and psychology (Reimann et al., 2012). More than three decades later, however, the debate over consumer relationships remains contested.

In contemporary research, marketing scholars continue to engage in intellectual discussions on the theoretical foundations of consumer relationships (Hütten et al., 2018; Safari and Albaum, 2019; Connors et al., 2021; Berg, 2022; Badrinarayanan and Ramachandran, 2024; Madhavaram, 2024; Iveson et al., 2026; Safari, 2026). This debate is grounded in a historical lack of scholarly consensus about the existence of B2C relationships. On the one hand, some studies question the idea that retailers and end consumers can have relationships, arguing that such exchanges lack the relational characteristics found in interpersonal and B2B relationships (O'Malley and Tynan, 1999; O'Malley, 2001; O'Malley and Tynan, 2000) and that, given the large number of buyers, B2C exchanges remain inherently transactional in nature (Barnes, 1994; Leahy, 2011; Lee and Xiong, 2026). On the other hand, others contend that while B2C relationships differ in nature from B2B relationships, they nonetheless exist and take a different form, as consumers seek to simplify their choices, enhance purchasing efficiency, and reduce uncertainty by developing trust and commitment (Bagozzi, 1995; Gruen, 1995; Peterson, 1995; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Fournier, 1998; Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Pels, 1999; Safari, 2014; Iveson et al., 2026). In other words, the marketing literature remains divided by an ongoing debate over whether consumer purchases are transactional or relational (Bennett, 1996; Leahy, 2011; Safari and Albaum, 2019; Lee and Xiong, 2026). In recent years, the discussion has shifted toward broader recognition of relational thought, where consumer relationships are widely accepted and supported within marketing scholarship (Steinhoff et al., 2019; Alvarez et al., 2023; Iveson et al., 2026; Safari, 2026). Thus, an extensive body of research has contributed to studying, explaining, and theorizing consumer relationships (e.g., O'Malley and Tynan, 2000; De Wulf et al., 2001; Bhattacharya and Sen, 2003; Ching and Ellis, 2006; Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Pavlou et al., 2007; Wang et al., 2016; Zhang et al., 2016; Cui et al., 2020; Connors et al., 2021; Lin et al., 2023).

However, there remains substantial scope for advancing knowledge of consumer relationships. Marketing scholars have repeatedly noted that theoretical progress in this area has mainly been incremental (Wulf and Odekerken-Schröder, 2001; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 2000; Davies et al., 2020; Sheth et al., 2024). Moreover, some have questioned whether RET adequately captures the breadth of marketing phenomena (Bilgihan and Bujisic, 2015; Brown et al., 2019). One central source of this incremental progress is the predominant focus of prior research on consumer relationships in low-uncertainty contexts

(e.g., Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Pavlou et al., 2007; Cui et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2023; Li et al., 2024). Low-uncertainty contexts are settings in which uncertainty is low due to the familiarity and availability of reliable information cues, enabling outcomes to be more readily anticipated (Pavlou et al., 2007). Hence, relationships tend to form more easily under such conditions, as they facilitate the development of consumer trust and commitment (Darke et al., 2016; Zerbini et al., 2022; Lee et al., 2026). But what happens to consumers' relationship development when such underlying conditions are missing? More specifically, how, if at all, do consumers develop relationships in high-uncertainty contexts? High-uncertainty contexts are settings in which uncertainty is high due to ambiguous, limited, or absent familiarity and information cues, making outcomes difficult to anticipate (Safari and Yamin, 2016; Lee et al., 2026). To date, existing research has paid scarce attention to how such relationships develop under these conditions. Instead, the current theoretical understanding of consumer relationships has largely been, and continues to be, shaped by low-uncertainty contexts. It is, nevertheless, also important to understand how relationships develop beyond these contexts, as this can provide a path forward for advancing knowledge in the marketing discipline on consumer relationship development. Therefore, *this thesis aims to study and increase understanding of consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts*.

To address this aim, the theoretical foundation of this thesis is RET. In high-uncertainty contexts, this thesis argues that uncertainty does not primarily activate price-based motivations; rather, it increases the need for trust and commitment to reduce uncertainty. This makes RET an appropriate theoretical lens, as it explains how trust and commitment guide relationship development when uncertainty cannot be resolved through the price mechanism alone, as TET suggests (Grönroos, 1994; Gruen, 1995; Rindfleisch, 2020). Accordingly, this aim is theoretically important, as it holds implications for RET. The theory has primarily been developed and validated in low-uncertainty contexts, where familiarity and accessible information cues support relationship development (Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007). In high-uncertainty contexts, where such conditions are absent, it remains unclear whether RET is applicable to explaining the development of consumer relationships. Consumers operate with limited familiarity and information cues, which can challenge the development of consumer relationships (Safari and Yamin, 2016; Lee et al., 2026). This raises a critical theoretical concern about the theory's ability to explain the development of consumer relationships in high-uncertainty contexts. In line with the view that “the purpose of theories is to increase scientific understanding by explaining and predicting phenomena” (Hunt, 2011, p. 76), examining RET beyond its original contexts is necessary to identify its applicability and explanatory scope. Testing and extending theories across different settings strengthens their relevance and contribution to scientific advancement (Madhavaram, 2024). Therefore, this thesis

pushes the boundary conditions of RET to high-uncertainty contexts. In doing so, it provides important theoretical insights into RET's strengths and limitations in explaining the development of consumer relationships under high-uncertainty contexts.

This thesis uses cross-border e-commerce (CBEC) as an empirical setting to study consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts. Purchasing in CBEC inherently involves uncertainty because consumers buy from retailers located in foreign countries, where language barriers and differences in legal systems make it difficult to assess product quality, payment security, and delivery reliability (Shao et al., 2021). To capture conditions in which consumer uncertainty is even more pronounced, this thesis focuses on a particular type of retailer in CBEC, namely, *partial online internationalization* (POI) *retailers* (Safari and Yamin, 2016), with which consumers can develop relationships. These retailers are smaller, resource-constrained foreign online firms that operate across national borders and lack an established reputation and familiarity among consumers (Daryanto et al., 2013; Schu and Morschett, 2017; Mueller and Swoboda, 2025). As a consequence, consumers lack prior experience, reliable information cues, and established reputational signals when interacting with POI-retailers, thereby creating a context characterized by high uncertainty. Moreover, in this specific context, the level of unfamiliarity is greater than, for example, in B2B settings (Håkansson, 1982; Johanson and Mattsson, 1987), as consumers typically have limited interconnected relationships that can assure them that the retailer can be trusted. For these reasons, POI-retailers in CBEC provide a particularly relevant empirical setting for studying consumer relationships in high-uncertainty contexts.

Previous studies

Uncertainty,[1] defined as the degree to which consumers can accurately anticipate future outcomes, has long been recognized as a key barrier to consumer purchasing and relationship development (Urbany et al., 1989; Pavlou et al., 2007; Khoblock, 2008; Shiu et al., 2011; Lu and Chen, 2021; Lin et al., 2023). It is shaped by the extent to which consumers have sufficient information to make decisions with confidence (Pavlou et al., 2007). The level of uncertainty

[1] There is a conceptual distinction between risk and uncertainty, where risk involves known or calculable probabilities and is typically associated with assumptions of rational decision-making, whereas uncertainty involves situations in which probabilities are unknown and is associated with bounded rationality in decision-making (Knight, 1921). Moreover, these two concepts have roots in different theoretical traditions in marketing: risk is more closely linked to TET due to its assumptions of perfect information and rationality (Levitt, 1960; Williamson, 1979; Rindfleisch, 2020), whereas uncertainty is primarily associated with RET due to its assumptions of incomplete information and bounded rationality (Dwyer et al., 1987; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 2000; Pavlou et al., 2007). In line with the thesis's theoretical foundation in the latter theory, the concept of uncertainty is therefore adopted.

consumers perceive depends largely on the nature of the purchasing context, which is determined by the availability of information cues (Lee et al, 2026). According to previous research, examples of such cues are related to seller characteristics (e.g., firm size, reputation, familiarity) (Gefen, 2000; Jarvenpaa et al., 2000; Eastlick et al., 2006), product characteristics (e.g., quality, description, price, country-of-origin) (Gefen et al., 2008; Zhu et al., 2019; Mou et al., 2020a; Mou et al., 2020b; Shao et al., 2021; Sun et al., 2022), website characteristics (e.g., website design, privacy, security) (Gefen et al., 2003; Chen and Yang, 2021; Chen et al., 2025; Sharma and Klein, 2025), and country characteristics (e.g., language, culture, legal system, customer protection) (Harrison-Walker, 2002; Safari et al., 2013; Huang and Chang, 2019; Shao et al., 2021). For consumers, these cues can indicate the extent to which the retailer is committed to helping them reduce uncertainty (Tiessen et al., 2001; Mueller and Swoboda, 2025). According to Lee et al. (2026), in some purchasing contexts, consumers have access to strong, reliable information cues, leading to low uncertainty. In other cases, such cues are weak or absent; hence, uncertainty remains high. At a higher level of abstraction, this thesis categorizes these purchasing contexts as low-uncertainty and high-uncertainty. The following sections review prior studies in each of these uncertainty contexts, with a particular focus on the body of knowledge on consumer relationships within each context.

Consumer Relationships in Low-Uncertainty Contexts

Low-uncertainty contexts are characterized by purchasing settings where reliable and accessible information cues are present (Lee et al., 2026). Research highlights two empirical examples of consumer purchasing contexts with low uncertainty: (1) the domestic e-commerce setting, where consumers purchase from domestic online retailers located in the same country (Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Al-Debei et al., 2015; Akroush and Al-Debei, 2015; Lin et al., 2023; Yan et al., 2023; Li et al., 2024) and (2) the cross-border e-commerce (CBEC) setting, where consumers purchase from large, well-known multinational online retailers located abroad[2] (Cyr et al., 2005; Singh et al., 2006; Zhu et al., 2019; Mou et al., 2020b; Yang et al., 2023). Low-uncertainty contexts include cues such as familiarity, well-branded retailers, clear product descriptions, straightforward websites, transparent policies, and no language barriers. It is, however, essential to clarify that uncertainty is not entirely absent in these contexts. Studies show that consumers still perceive uncertainty related to the retailer and the product (Pavlou et al., 2007; Mou et al., 2020b; Sun et al., 2022). Nevertheless, because cues such as retailer familiarity and detailed

[2] Also known as active online internationalization (AOI) retailers (Yamin and Sinkovics, 2006; Safari and Yamin, 2016; Ipsmiller et al., 2022).

product information are available (Jarvenpaa et al., 2000; Mou et al., 2020b), these uncertainties remain relatively low. As a result, it becomes easier for consumers to develop relationships with retailers in these contexts, as they can anticipate future outcomes with much greater confidence.

Previous research has contributed a substantial body of knowledge on consumer relationships in low-uncertainty contexts (e.g., Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Wang et al., 2016; Cui et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2023). A recurring pattern in this literature is that trust, commitment, and uncertainty are the central theoretical concepts explaining how consumers initiate and build relationships with retailers (Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Gruen, 1995; Eastlick et al., 2006; Lin et al., 2023). Accordingly, a substantial body of research has examined trust and commitment in consumer relationships, including their antecedents and outcomes. Prior research has identified several antecedents common to both trust and commitment, most notably satisfaction (Li et al., 2006; Wang et al., 2016; Cui et al., 2020) and perceived value (Wang et al., 2016). In addition to these shared antecedents, trust is influenced by opportunistic behavior (Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Cui et al., 2020), perceived reputation (Jarvenpaa et al., 2000; Eastlick et al., 2006), size of the retailer (Jarvenpaa et al., 2000), experience, familiarity (Gefen, 2000), privacy concerns (Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007), website design (Darke et al., 2016), as well as perceived ease of use and perceived usefulness that underpin the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) (Gefen et al., 2003; Cho and Sagynov, 2015; Chen and Yang, 2021; Zerbini et al., 2022; Taufique et al., 2024). Moreover, previous studies have found a significant relationship between trust and consumer attitudes (Al-Debei et al., 2015; Akroush and Al-Debei, 2015; Moriuchi, 2021; Yan et al., 2023; Li et al., 2024).

Commitment, in contrast, has been linked to investment size (Li et al., 2006), termination cost (Mukherjee and Nath, 2007), and trust (Li et al., 2006; Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Wang et al., 2016; Cui et al., 2020). Moreover, prior research consistently positions trust as preceding commitment, with both serving as central mediating variables in consumer relationship models (Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Wang et al., 2016; Cui et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2023). Consistent with this, trust and commitment have been shown to influence key behavioral outcomes, including purchase intention (Li et al., 2006; Wang et al., 2016; Darke et al., 2016; Huang and Chang, 2019; Cui et al., 2020), repurchase intention (Nora, 2019; Antwi, 2021), stickiness intention (Li et al., 2006; Wang et al., 2016), and participating in a relationship (Palvia, 2009).

While most studies have focused on trust and commitment, uncertainty is often treated as a background condition that diminishes and shapes their roles (Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Gruen, 1995; Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Wang et al., 2016; Lin et al., 2023). By contrast, a smaller body of studies places uncertainty at the center of relationship development (e.g., Pavlou et al., 2007; Mou et al., 2020b). These studies offer important

insights, suggesting that uncertainty should not be viewed as a background condition or a single, unidimensional concept, but rather as a multidimensional construct originating from different sources (Pavlou et al., 2007; Mou et al., 2020b). In this regard, Pavlou et al. (2007) and Mou et al. (2020b) both examine uncertainty in consumer relationships, but they do so at different phases of relationship development and focus on a narrow set of uncertainty sources that are expected to diminish as relationships develop. Pavlou et al. (2007) focus primarily on the initial phase, in which product and retailer uncertainty shape purchase intention, whereas Mou et al. (2020b) examine a more established relationship in which these uncertainties influence repurchase intention. Other studies have focused on outcomes, showing that uncertainty is associated with negative attitudes (Quintal et al., 2010; Sun et al., 2022). Based on the above, this body of work has contributed substantial empirical and theoretical knowledge on how consumer relationships develop and how uncertainty influences this development. However, these insights are predominantly derived from studies conducted in low-uncertainty contexts. As a result, the current theoretical understanding of both consumer relationship development and the role of uncertainty is largely grounded in conditions characterized by relatively low uncertainty.

Consumer Relationships in High-Uncertainty Contexts

In contrast to the accessible information cues available in low-uncertainty contexts, such cues are weak or absent in high-uncertainty contexts (Lee et al., 2026). Thus, these contexts are characterized by unfamiliarity, weakly branded retailers, limited choices of reliable payment methods, ambiguous product descriptions, low-effort websites, a lack of clear information about policies, and language barriers that hinder effective customer support (Kotha et al., 2001; Tiessen et al., 2001; Harrison-Walker, 2002; Chen et al., 2025). Research highlights two empirical examples of consumer purchasing settings characterized by high uncertainty, namely (1) the CBEC setting, where consumers can purchase from online retailers even though these retailers focus solely on their home-country consumers[3] (Safari, 2012; Safari and Thilenius, 2013; Safari et al., 2013; Huang and Chang, 2019; Wagner et al., 2024) and (2) the CBEC setting, where consumers purchase from foreign, smaller, less-branded online retailers[4] (Daryanto et al., 2013; Safari and Yamin, 2016).

[3] Also known as default online internationalization (DOI) retailers (Yamin and Sinkovics, 2006; Safari and Yamin, 2016; Ipsmiller et al., 2022).

[4] Also known as partial online internationalization (POI) retailers (Safari and Yamin, 2016). Others label it as a retailer developing a "market-specific shop" (Shneor and Flåten, 2008), "country-specific website" (Kotha et al., 2001; Daryanto et al., 2013), or "country-specific online shop" in CBEC (Swoboda and Sinning, 2022; Mueller and Swoboda, 2025). In this thesis, it is labeled as a POI-retailer.

In contrast to the first type, where retailers are not investing in consumers outside their home country (Safari, 2012; Sinkovics et al., 2013; Safari, 2014), the second type includes retailers that intend to reduce uncertainty by making resource investments (Safari and Yamin, 2016; Schu and Morschett, 2017; Swoboda and Sinning, 2022; Mueller and Swoboda, 2025). They, however, face difficulties in doing so because of their constrained resources, which consequently restricts their ability to build consumer trust (Sinkovics et al., 2007; Daryanto et al., 2013). Therefore, they fall short of providing reliable informational cues compared with larger multinational retailers in low-uncertainty contexts (Hu et al., 2024). Given their resource disadvantage, it becomes significantly more difficult for consumers to anticipate future outcomes with confidence (Pavlou et al., 2007), thereby heightening uncertainty (Safari and Yamin, 2016).

Although prior research identifies two settings characterized by high uncertainty, it is important to clarify that this thesis adopts the second type of high-uncertainty context. Most studies have focused on consumer relationship development within the first type of high-uncertainty context (e.g., Safari, 2012; Safari and Thilenius, 2013; Safari et al., 2013; Huang and Chang, 2019; Wagner et al., 2024), with scarce attention to the second type of high-uncertainty context. Importantly, prior research suggests that retailers in the first type of high-uncertainty context do not intend to develop relationships with foreign consumers, as their resource investments are directed toward consumers in their domestic market (Ipsmiller et al., 2022). In contrast, retailers in the second type actively invest resources and intend to develop relationships with foreign consumers by engaging in cross-border activities (Safari and Yamin, 2016). However, they face difficulties due to resource constraints and unfamiliarity (Daryanto et al., 2013); hence, consumer uncertainty remains higher than in, for example, domestic e-commerce and CBEC involving multinational, well-known retailers. By studying consumer relationships with these specific retailers in this context, this thesis not only provides practical insights but also addresses an overlooked aspect of how such relationships develop under high uncertainty.

While research on consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts remains limited, a few studies have nevertheless provided valuable insights into these settings. For instance, Safari and Yamin (2016) offer a conceptual framework for understanding consumers' perceived uncertainty. They argue that consumers engage in search and deliberation activities. However, if consumers face difficulties in reducing heightened uncertainty, they tend to shift to low-uncertainty contexts, as search and deliberation become less challenging (Safari and Yamin, 2016). Others have focused on consumer uncertainty and trust in the first type of CBEC high-uncertainty context (Safari, 2012; Safari and Thilenius, 2013; Safari et al., 2013). Safari (2012) found that consumer trust is multidimensional, comprising trust in the retailer's website, the retailer's country of residence, and the retailer itself. In their study, Safari

and Thilenius (2013) found that uncertainty hampers the development of consumer trust; however, once trust develops, it can, in turn, help alleviate this uncertainty. Other examples include studies that adopt a retailer's perspective and examine its behavior and the strategies used to enhance consumer purchasing under high uncertainty (Sinkovics et al., 2007; Daryanto et al., 2013; Schu and Morschett, 2017; Swoboda and Sinning, 2022; Mueller and Swoboda, 2025). These findings indicate that smaller retailers, due to limited resources, struggle to attract and retain consumers, as these constraints limit their ability to invest in trust-building cues that can reduce consumer uncertainty (Sinkovics et al., 2007; Ipsmiller et al., 2022).

However, while these studies offer valuable insights, existing research falls short in two critical aspects: (1) identifying the types of uncertainty that affect consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts and (2) understanding how consumers nevertheless attempt to develop relationships under such conditions. Examining these aspects is important because it enables a theoretical understanding of both the specific barriers that hinder relationship development and the ways consumers seek to build relationships despite them. Beyond its theoretical relevance, studying this topic is also important from a managerial perspective. Prior research indicates that smaller retailers often struggle to attract and retain consumers due to constrained resources (Daryanto et al., 2013; Schu and Morschett, 2017). Identifying the types of uncertainty that impede consumer relationship development, as well as understanding how relationships develop despite such uncertainty, provides guidance for smaller, resource-constrained retailers on where to allocate resources to facilitate consumer relationship development. Addressing these issues, therefore, offers valuable insights for both theory and practice. Accordingly, the next section presents the central research questions addressed in this thesis, grounded in these two considerations.

Specifying the Research Questions

The theoretical foundation of this thesis is RET, with the aim of studying and increasing the understanding of consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts. RET was originally introduced in the marketing literature to explain B2B relationships (Dwyer et al., 1987; Johanson and Mattsson, 1987) and was later extended to consumer markets (Pels, 1999; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995). Over time, marketing scholars have developed a robust body of knowledge that underpins RET. However, most research has examined relationships in low-uncertainty contexts (e.g., De Wulf et al., 2001; Bhattacharya and Sen, 2003; Ching and Ellis, 2006; Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Pavlou et al., 2007; Wang et al., 2016; Zhang et al., 2016; Cui et al., 2020; Connors et al., 2021; Lin et al., 2023). Extending established theories to new contexts is essential for advancing scientific

knowledge, as it allows researchers to examine the conditions under which existing theoretical explanations hold and whether their explanatory scope requires refinement (Hunt, 2011; MacInnis, 2011; Jaakkola, 2020). Unlike previous studies, this thesis extends RET to high-uncertainty contexts beyond those in which it has primarily been applied and developed. The literature review above indicates that research on consumer relationship development in such contexts is limited. As a result, several important questions remain unanswered, and this thesis seeks to address two of them.

Previous studies drawing on RET show that uncertainty has important implications for relationship development (Eastlick et al., 2006; Pavlou et al., 2007; Mou et al., 2020b). Specifically, research suggests that uncertainty tends to decrease as relationships develop (Ford, 1980; Dwyer et al., 1987; Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Safari and Albaum, 2019). At the same time, when consumers are unable to reduce uncertainty, they may be hindered from initiating and developing relationships (Pavlou et al., 2007; Safari and Thilenius, 2013). Accordingly, although these studies indicate that uncertainty plays a central role in determining whether consumer relationships emerge and continue to develop, much of the RET-based literature treats uncertainty primarily as a background condition that gradually diminishes through repeated interactions and trust-building (Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Gruen, 1995; Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Wang et al., 2016; Lin et al., 2023). As a result, the role of uncertainty in shaping relationship development has often been discussed conceptually rather than explicitly examined. Only a limited number of studies place uncertainty at the center of relationship development (Ford, 1980; Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Ford and Mouzas, 2010) and demonstrate that consumers experience different types of uncertainty (Pavlou et al., 2007; Mou et al., 2020b). Specifically, consumers face uncertainty about the retailer and the product, which are identified at different phases of relationship development (Pavlou et al., 2007; Mou et al., 2020b).

Although prior studies advance understanding of uncertainty in relationship development, their insights are derived almost exclusively from low-uncertainty contexts. This constitutes a fundamental theoretical limitation, as such contexts differ markedly from high-uncertainty contexts (Lee et al., 2026). In low-uncertainty contexts, uncertainty tends to be limited in scope and primarily tied to the retailer and the product (Pavlou et al., 2007; Mou et al., 2020b). In contrast, when uncertainty is high, it can be expected to stem from multiple sources and thus not be limited to the product and the retailer. Despite this, existing RET-based research does not specify what types of uncertainty consumers encounter in high-uncertainty contexts, nor how these uncertainties affect relationship development (Ford, 1980; Dwyer et al., 1987; Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Pavlou et al., 2007; Ford and Mouzas, 2010; Mou et al., 2020b). This limitation is theoretically significant because RET largely posits that uncertainty decreases as relationships develop (Ford, 1980; Dwyer

et al., 1987; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995); a view grounded in contexts where initial uncertainty is relatively low due to the availability of reliable information and familiarity cues (Pavlou et al., 2007; Mou et al., 2020b). However, when uncertainty is high at the outset, persists, and takes multiple forms, reducing it becomes much more difficult, which may fundamentally shape how relationships develop. This raises important considerations regarding RET's ability to account for relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts, where uncertainty can be multifaceted, persistent, and more difficult to reduce.

Based on the above, this thesis emphasizes the importance of understanding which types of uncertainty affect the development of consumer relationships in high-uncertainty contexts. In these contexts, consumers often lack important cues that typically help reduce uncertainty, including those related to the retailer (Gefen, 2000; Jarvenpaa et al., 2000; Eastlick et al., 2006), the product (Gefen et al., 2008; Zhu et al., 2019; Mou et al., 2020a; Mou et al., 2020b; Shao et al., 2021; Sun et al., 2022), the website (Gefen et al., 2003; Chen and Yang, 2021; Chen et al., 2025; Sharma and Klein, 2025), and the country (Harrison-Walker, 2002; Safari et al., 2013; Huang and Chang, 2019; Shao et al., 2021). In the absence of such cues, uncertainty cannot be considered limited or singular; rather, it is likely to arise from multiple sources and persist even as relationships begin to form and develop. Identifying the types of uncertainty is therefore essential to understanding their effects on the development of consumer relationships in high-uncertainty contexts, as different types of uncertainty can both constrain and shape this development. Moreover, studying these dynamics can advance RET by strengthening its ability to explain how trust and commitment form, as these relational elements underpin relationship development and are shaped by the specific uncertainties consumers seek to resolve (Pavlou et al., 2007). Therefore, this thesis is guided by the first research question:

What types of uncertainty affect consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts?

Prior research grounded in RET has focused on how relationships develop. These studies have proposed various conceptual frameworks of relationship development (e.g., Dwyer et al., 1987; Ford, 1980; Evans and Laskin, 1994; Wilson, 1995; Fournier, 1998; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 2000; Wang et al., 2000; Hadjikhani and Bengtson, 2006; Campbell et al., 2009; Campbell, 2019). While these frameworks provide useful insights, they offer limited guidance on how consumers develop relationships in high-uncertainty contexts for several reasons. First, existing conceptual frameworks explain how relationships develop in low-uncertainty contexts, where uncertainty is relatively low at the outset and gradually decreases as relationships develop. However, studies suggest that low- and high-uncertainty contexts differ fundamentally (Lin et al., 2023; Lee et al., 2026), indicating that existing frameworks in the literature

may not be applicable to high-uncertainty contexts. This highlights the need for a framework that explicitly accounts for the unique nature of these contexts to explain how relationships develop.

Secondly, most existing conceptual frameworks are not only developed for low-uncertainty contexts but are also predominantly designed to explain how B2B relationships develop in such contexts (e.g., Dwyer et al., 1987; Ford, 1980; Larson, 1992; Wilson, 1995; Batonda and Perry, 2003). Conceptual frameworks that explicitly address consumer relationship development remain relatively scarce, with only a few notable exceptions (e.g., Fournier, 1998; Wang et al., 2000; Hadjikhani and Bengtson, 2006; Campbell et al., 2009; Campbell, 2019). Given that prior studies suggest B2B and B2C relationships differ fundamentally in nature (Gruen, 1995; Hunt, 2013; Safari and Albaum, 2019), these predominantly B2B-oriented frameworks provide limited guidance on how consumer relationships develop. Therefore, there is a clear need for more research that accounts not only for the distinctive nature of consumer relationships but also for how such relationships develop in high-uncertainty contexts.

Based on the above, understanding how consumer relationships develop in high-uncertainty contexts remains limited. As these contexts differ fundamentally from those underpinning existing RET-based literature, the applicability of these frameworks is constrained, providing limited guidance on how relationships are initiated and evolve under high uncertainty. Addressing this limitation is therefore essential for advancing theoretical understanding of consumer relationship development in such contexts. Therefore, this thesis is guided by the second research question:

How do consumers develop relationships in high-uncertainty contexts?

These two research questions have important implications for advancing research on consumer relationships within RET. This thesis not only extends the theory's boundary conditions to high-uncertainty contexts but also examines its applicability in B2C markets to study the development of consumer relationships under heightened uncertainty. In doing so, it provides insights into both RET's explanatory strengths and limitations. The findings are relevant not only for understanding consumer relationships under high uncertainty but also, more broadly, for advancing consumer relationships. While these research questions are theoretically motivated, they also have important empirical relevance.

Specifically, studying consumer relationship development has been recognized as methodologically demanding (Iacobucci and Hibbard, 1999; Safari and Albaum, 2019). Even in low-uncertainty contexts, relationships unfold gradually through repeated interactions and purchases, making them difficult to capture empirically (Hadjikhani and LaPlaca, 2013; Safari and Albaum, 2019; Shamsollahi et al., 2021). Because of these challenges, many

studies focus on the initial purchases and use RET to explain early outcomes such as purchase intention (Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Cui et al., 2020). While some scholars have criticized this approach, noting that initial purchases resemble a discrete transaction rather than a relationship (Leahy, 2011), it is important to acknowledge that capturing relationship development is inherently difficult (Shamsollahi et al., 2021). As a result, most studies focus empirically on a specific phase of the relationship (Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Pavlou et al., 2007; Cui et al., 2020; Wang et al., 2016; Li et al., 2023), leaving the overall development of consumer relationships largely unexplored due to the empirical difficulties involved.

Based on this, studying consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts is expected to be even more demanding. In such contexts, it is important to account for persistent uncertainty, limited prior experience, and the absence of familiarity and reliable information cues, all of which make it more difficult to observe how relationships emerge and develop, if at all. While prior research has acknowledged the theoretical and empirical challenges of studying consumer relationships (e.g., Iacobucci and Hibbard, 1999; Hadjikhani and LaPlaca, 2013; Safari and Albaum, 2019), addressing these challenges remains crucial for knowledge development in the marketing discipline. Hence, this thesis focuses on consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts to increase knowledge in this area.

Before moving to the next chapters, it is important to clarify several questions that may arise at this stage. Specifically, RET encompasses multiple definitions of relationship marketing (e.g., Berry, 1983; Evans and Laskin, 1994; Grönroos, 1994; Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Harker, 1999; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 2000), different schools of thought (e.g., Ford, 1980; Håkansson, 1982; Dwyer et al., 1987; Christopher et al., 1991; Grönroos, 1994; Gummesson, 1994; Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995), diverse relational perspectives, and a variety of definitions of key theoretical concepts across both B2B and B2C markets (e.g., Gruen, 1995; Hunt, 2013; Safari and Albaum, 2019). For this reason, it is important to clarify and explicitly discuss where this thesis is situated within this extensive body of knowledge, as this will inform its theoretical reasoning.

First, a definition of a relationship may reasonably be expected in this thesis. This is a valid point, as both the research questions and the overall aim focus on how consumers develop relationships in high-uncertainty contexts. At first glance, defining the term "relationship" may seem simple. However, as soon as one begins to examine how the concept is treated in the RET literature, it becomes anything but straightforward. Scholars have offered numerous definitions, although without consensus, of "relationship marketing" (e.g., see Berry, 1983; Evans and Laskin, 1994; Grönroos, 1994; Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Harker, 1999; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 2000) and even of "marketing" (e.g., Kotler, 1972; Bartels, 1974; Bagozzi, 1975; Hunt, 1976; Houston and

Gassenheimer, 1987). Yet defining the concept of a "relationship" has proven far more challenging (Hütten et al., 2018; Badrinarayanan and Ramachandran, 2024). As Blocker et al. (2012, p. 888) state, "The definition of relationship has proven difficult. […] Scholars usually do not define "relationship" precisely, and the term lacks connotative force. Thus, they use broad conceptualizations that may reflect […] relationships." Accordingly, defining the term "relationship" has sparked a considerable debate within marketing (Hadjikhani and LaPlaca, 2013) as well as in fields such as psychology and sociology (Huston and Burgess, 1979; Huston and Robins, 1982). Indeed, over four decades ago, Huston and Robins (1982, p. 902) opened their theoretical chapter with the simple question, "What is a relationship?" Interestingly, more than three decades later, Hadjikhani and LaPlaca (2013, p. 303) returned to this question when they concluded their article by asking, once again, "What is a relationship?" To date, a clear answer to this question has largely been absent (Palmatier et al., 2006; Sheth et al., 2024), leading some scholars to question whether the term functions mostly as a rhetorical label (O'Malley and Tynan, 1999; O'Malley and Tynan, 2000).

Nevertheless, scholars have studied relationships and continue to do so in contemporary research (Alvarez et al., 2023; Iveson et al., 2026). In the absence of a clearly articulated definition, Blocker et al. (2012) argue that scholars typically address this challenge by describing the key ingredients and characteristics through which a relationship is broadly understood. An example of this can be found in the study by Snehota and Håkansson (1995, p. 38), who state, "It is not easy to define what a relationship is. Tentatively we can say that a relationship is *mutually oriented interaction* between two *reciprocally committed parties*. One reason why we choose the notion of relationship in analysis of intercompany *interaction* is that it evokes the concepts of *mutual orientation* and *commitment* over time" (emphasis added). Consistent with this perspective, scholars typically describe relationships as being characterized by active parties, interaction, high adaptation, interdependence, long-term orientation, heterogeneity, mutuality, bounded rationality, low opportunistic behavior, trust, and commitment (Dwyer et al., 1987; Ford, 1980; Wilson, 1995; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 2000; Safari and Albaum, 2019). Many of these characteristics, however, stem from relationships studied in B2B markets (Blocker et al., 2012). It is therefore important to account for the nature of B2C markets, as several studies highlight fundamental differences between B2B and B2C relationships (Gruen, 1995; Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Hunt, 2013; Safari and Albaum, 2019; Safari, 2026).

The objective of the discussion above is not to suggest that this thesis seeks to resolve this longstanding definitional puzzle. Instead, it recognizes that defining a relationship is challenging even for scholars with decades of experience studying relationships (e.g., Snehota and Håkansson, 1995; Blocker et al., 2012; Hadjikhani and LaPlaca, 2013), making it even less feasible within the scope of this thesis. This does not mean, however, that clarifying how this

thesis views a relationship is overlooked; rather, some guidance on what a relationship refers to is necessary for conceptual clarity. To address this definitional issue, this thesis draws on the work of well-established scholars and focuses on the core elements that comprise a relationship (Gruen, 1995; Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Blocker et al., 2012). Accordingly, in this thesis, a consumer relationship refers to the development of trust and commitment by consumers to reduce uncertainty in high-uncertainty contexts. This "definition" is adopted because prior research consistently identifies trust and commitment as the core mechanisms through which uncertainty is reduced and consumer relationships are formed and sustained (Gruen, 1995; Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Eastlick et al., 2006; Li et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Wang et al., 2016; Nora, 2019; Cui et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2023). In their recent literature review, Badrinarayanan and Ramachandran (2024) demonstrate that trust and commitment constitute the central building blocks of relationship development across different settings. Similarly, Brown et al. (2019, p. 155) emphasize that "trust and commitment are key constructs in the study of relationships."

Second, while prior research has raised critiques regarding the use of the term "relationship" and the application of RET in consumer markets (Barnes, 1994; Tynan, 1997; O'Malley and Tynan, 2000; Leahy, 2011), this thesis follows studies that demonstrate the relevance of relational perspectives in B2C settings (Gruen, 1995; Eastlick et al., 2006; Pavlou et al., 2007; Steinhoff et al., 2019). These studies show that relationship development can create value for both consumers and retailers and play an important role in reducing consumer uncertainty. On this basis, this thesis adopts relationships as a theoretical lens to understand exchange that extends beyond opportunism and discrete, short-term transactions. Instead, it emphasizes a long-term orientation that incorporates relational elements that enables to reduce uncertainty (Gruen, 1995; Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 2000; Eastlick et al., 2006; Pavlou et al., 2007; Safari and Albaum, 2019).

Third, some questions may arise about why this thesis focuses only on the consumer's point of view, given that a relationship typically involves at least two parties. While this is a reasonable concern, studying relationships is far less simple than it may initially appear, and scholars have struggled with this issue for decades (Grönroos, 1994). Relationships can take various forms, including dyadic (Morgan and Hunt, 1994), triadic (Havila et al., 2004), and networked relationships (Anderson et al., 1994; Safari, 2025), among others (Gummesson, 1995). A common critique when researchers study relationships is why they do not examine all parties, since it is commonly assumed that all parties must be included to say something meaningful about the relationship (Tanskanen, 2015). While viewing relationships as networks highlights their inherent complexity by requiring the consideration of multiple parties and interrelated relationships (Safari, 2025), focusing on two parties in a relationship does not make them easier to study. According to Hadjikhani and LaPlaca

(2013), even the simplest dyad is complex, as it encompasses both economic and social dimensions that evolve over longer periods. There are, of course, exceptions where studies examine both parties (e.g., Edvardsson et al., 2008; Tanskanen, 2015).

However, such approaches are less common because collecting comparable insights from both sides is rarely feasible in practice and involves considerable methodological and empirical challenges (Thibaut and Kelley, 1959; Huston and Robins, 1982; Hadjikhani and LaPlaca, 2013). Since marketing has borrowed many of its foundational ideas about relationships from social psychology (Tynan, 1997; Lambe et al., 2001), social psychologists have long acknowledged the methodological challenges involved and often shifted their focus to studying one party's perspective in relation to a significant other (Huston and Robins, 1982; Knobloch, 2008). These issues were later raised by marketing scholars (e.g., Dwyer et al., 1987). To solve these methodological issues, marketing research has largely inherited the social-psychological tradition of focusing on one party's perspective within the relationship. Therefore, marketing scholars have traditionally studied only one party in the relationship, and this approach is shared by many leading and well-established scholars in marketing (e.g., Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Pavlou et al., 2007).

Building on these established research traditions, this thesis adopts the same logic as previous studies by examining only one party's perspective in the relationship (e.g., Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Pavlou et al., 2007). In this regard, the thesis focuses solely on the consumer's perspective in the B2C relationship. This focus may still raise concerns among some readers about how a relationship can be meaningfully studied when only one party's perspective is considered. Beyond the justification outlined above, this approach is also appropriate because the central interest of this thesis lies in understanding what types of uncertainty affect consumer relationship development when consumers encounter retailers in high-uncertainty contexts, and how they nonetheless attempt to develop relationships under such conditions. In other words, such insights cannot be obtained from the retailer's perspective, which is why this thesis focuses on the consumer's perspective in the relationship.

Lastly, this thesis aims to study and increase understanding of consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts. Therefore, it focuses on relationship *development*, where "development" is understood as the progression from the consumer's first encounter with a retailer to the point at which a relationship is established. This understanding is consistent with the Oxford English Dictionary (2026), which defines development as "the steady growth of something so that it becomes more advanced and stronger," where the "something" in this thesis is the consumer relationship. Moreover, the use of the term "development" is consistent with prior RET research (e.g., Ford, 1980; Batonda and Perry, 2003), in which it is used to describe how

relationships form and strengthen. Accordingly, the thesis does not focus on relationship maturity or potential dissolution but instead examines the path toward developing a relationship. At the same time, given the heightened uncertainty consumers encounter in high-uncertainty contexts, it is acknowledged that, first, not all consumers will develop relationships with retailers and, second, even if some do, those relationships may eventually end. This thesis neither seeks to explain this potential avoidance nor the dissolution of the relationship. Instead, given the limited research on consumer relationships in high-uncertainty contexts, it begins by examining how these relationships develop as consumers engage in relational activities.

Structure of the Thesis

The rest of this thesis is structured as follows. The second chapter presents the theoretical background by first discussing the two foundational paths in marketing, namely TET and RET, and then focusing exclusively on RET, which serves as the theoretical foundation of this thesis. While this thesis focuses on consumer relationships, the theoretical chapter discusses RET's application in both B2B and B2C markets. This is because the theory was originally developed in B2B contexts and later extended to B2C, sparking a debate in the marketing literature and, over time, shaping how B2C relationships are conceptualized in contemporary research. Understanding RET's historical evolution and contemporary perspectives on consumer relationships is therefore important for the thesis's theoretical positioning, as it underpins its assumptions, reasoning, and definitions.

The third chapter outlines the method, beginning with an explanation of this thesis's empirical research context, namely, POI-retailers in CBEC, as an empirical illustration of a high-uncertainty context in which consumers can develop relationships. This is followed by a detailed explanation of the thesis's research design across the three studies underpinning its four papers. Specifically, it explains how the thesis adopts a multi-phase approach consisting of an exploratory phase (Study 1 for Paper I), which systematically reviews the consumer CBEC literature; a confirmatory phase (Study 2 for Papers II and III), which tests RET in a high-uncertainty context; and an explicatory phase (Study 3, comprising sub-studies 3a, 3b, and 3c, for Paper IV), which seeks to explain and understand how consumer relationships develop, given that the confirmatory phase revealed limitations of RET in explaining such relationships in high-uncertainty contexts. The chapter proceeds with an explanation of the data collection, sample, and analytical procedures used in each of the three studies conducted in this thesis.

The fourth chapter presents the four papers of the thesis. Paper I is a systematic literature review that combines quantitative and qualitative methods, revealing that consumer relationships in high-uncertainty contexts remain

underexplored and that consumers face different types of uncertainty in these contexts. Building on these insights, Papers II and III use quantitative methods to examine the initial phase of consumer relationship development and the types of uncertainty that affect it, thereby testing RET's applicability beyond the low-uncertainty contexts in which it was originally developed. Surprisingly, the findings show that the initial phase of consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts differs from what prior RET-based studies suggest. For this reason, Paper IV adopts a qualitative method to gain an in-depth understanding of how consumer relationships develop and the types of uncertainty that affect consumers throughout this development.

Based on insights from the four papers, which show that consumer relationships develop differently than RET suggests, the fifth chapter discusses these findings and hence introduces a conceptual framework for consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts. In doing so, it refines RET to account for such conditions and proposes that consumer relationships develop across three phases: the initial phase, the building phase, and the relationship phase, with trust, commitment, and uncertainty playing different and evolving roles throughout the development. Across these phases, consumers encounter six types of uncertainty, which influence the roles of trust and commitment and, hence, shape how the relationship develops.

Lastly, the sixth chapter presents the thesis's concluding remarks. It discusses the theoretical contributions and, in particular, what they imply for one of marketing's foundational theories, RET. The chapter also outlines managerial implications, limitations, as well as directions for future research.

2. Theory

Two Foundational Theoretical Paths in Marketing: Transactional and Relational Exchange Theories

In marketing, there are two foundational theoretical paths, namely Transactional Exchange Theory (TET) and Relational Exchange Theory (RET). All other theories are mid-range/sub-theories derived from the roots of these two general theories (Dwyer et al., 1987; Safari and Albaum, 2019). Both TET and RET have origins and borrow ideas from other theories in other fields. Specifically, TET was introduced in the marketing field in the 1960s (McCarthy, 1960; Borden, 1964; Kotler, 1967; Kotler, 1972) but has its roots in economic thought, particularly neoclassical economics (Jevons, 1871; Menger, 1871; Walras, 1874; Marshall, 1890) and transaction cost economics (Coase, 1937; Coase, 1960; Williamson, 1979; Coase, 1988; Williamson, 1993). TET is grounded in assumptions of short-term orientation, rational decision-making, homogeneity, maximization, and self-interest, whereby parties engage in opportunistic behavior, whenever possible, to safeguard their short-term interests (Levitt, 1960; Williamson, 1979; Williamson, 1993; Lee and Xiong, 2026). TET conceptualizes exchange as discrete economic transactions in which the purchase represents the end destination, with seller and buyer behavior primarily driven by profit maximization and price mechanism, respectively (Williamson, 1979; Rindfleisch, 2020).

However, the development of RET in the 1980s sparked an extensive debate within the marketing discipline regarding whether TET or RET constitutes the superior theory (Grönroos, 1994; Li and Nicholls, 2000). On the one hand, TET was valued for its practicality and relative ease in studying transactions, yet it proved limited in explaining exchange beyond discrete transactions (Grönroos, 1994). On the other hand, RET offered stronger explanatory power, but studying relationships was much more challenging because they are long term, interactive, and involve repeated purchases (Hadjikhani and LaPlaca, 2013). Given their robustness and parsimony, both have remained foundational paths in marketing, yet with an increasing emphasis on RET over the years (Harker and Egan, 2006; Madhavaram, 2024).

Accordingly, this thesis is theoretically grounded in RET, as it offers a suitable lens for studying the development of consumer relationships in high-uncertainty contexts. In this regard, the thesis is interested in

understanding long-term orientation. Unlike TET, which focuses on short-term, discrete exchanges (Rindfleisch, 2020), RET is grounded in a long-term perspective, viewing the purchase as the entry point for relationship development (Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Safari and Albaum, 2019). Moreover, this thesis follows previous RET-based research (Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Pavlou et al., 2007) and argues that uncertainty triggers the need for relational mechanisms, such as trust and commitment, rather than relying solely on price-based motivations. This follows from RET's view that relationships develop as a means of reducing uncertainty, with trust and commitment constituting the key mechanisms through which this reduction occurs (Dwyer et al., 1987; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 2000). To further understand the foundations of RET, the following sections provide a review of the RET literature.

Relational Exchange Theory

RET was developed in the 1980s to explain how exchange parties develop, maintain, and enhance long-term relationships (Ford, 1980; Håkansson, 1982). The theory has its roots in Behavioral theory (Cyert and March, 1963) and Social exchange theory (Homans, 1958; Thibaut and Kelley, 1959; Emerson, 1976). RET assumes that parties seek to engage in long-term, ongoing exchanges rather than isolated transactions, and that such exchanges are driven primarily by trust and commitment rather than only by price or other economic incentives (Grönroos, 1994; Ravald and Grönroos, 1996). Thus, RET is grounded in assumptions of active parties, interaction, adaptation, interdependence, long-term orientation, heterogeneity, mutuality, bounded rationality, and non-opportunistic behavior (Johanson and Mattsson, 1987; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 2000; Safari and Albaum, 2019). Accordingly, RET posits that parties develop relationships to reduce uncertainty, with trust and commitment as the core theoretical concepts underlying this development. Within RET, there are different definitions (Sheth and Parvatiyar, 2000; Hütten et al., 2018) and schools of thought (Sheth and Parvatiyar, 2000; Palmer et al., 2005; Harker and Egan, 2006), as well as differing views on how RET is applied to the study of B2B and B2C relationships (Gruen, 1995; Safari and Albaum, 2019; Safari, 2026).

To begin, there are various definitions of relationship marketing (e.g., Berry, 1983; Evans and Laskin, 1994; Grönroos, 1994; Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Harker, 1999; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 2000). It is important to clarify here that “RET” and “relationship marketing” are often used interchangeably in the literature; however, they all refer to the same broad relational thought, which conceptualizes exchange as relational (e.g., see Dwyer et al., 1987; Grönroos, 1994; Gundlach and Murphy, 1993; Gruen, 1995; Coviello and Brodie, 1998; Li and Nicholls, 2000; Pels et al., 2000; Rao and Perry, 2002). Accordingly,

some examples of definitions include Morgan and Hunt (1994, p. 22), who state, "Relationship marketing refers to all marketing activities directed toward establishing, developing, and maintaining successful relational exchanges." Another example is Berry (1983, p. 25) who states, "Relationship marketing is attracting, maintaining and – in multi-service organizations – enhancing customer relationships." According to Grönroos (1994, pp. 13-14), the definition of "Relationship marketing […] is a process including several parties or actors, the objectives of which have to be met. This is done by a mutual exchange and fulfillment of promises, a fact that makes trust an important aspect of marketing. […] Relationship marketing is also dynamic, because of its process nature." Moreover, Sheth and Parvatiyar (2000, p. 17) define relationship marketing "as a process of engaging in cooperative or collaborative relationship with customers." In other words, various definitions exist, yet across them, relationship marketing is consistently described as a focus on developing and maintaining long-term relationships.

In addition to its varying definitions, RET comprises four distinct schools of thought, which have given rise to various sub-theories and perspectives within the broader RET literature. The first school of thought, the Industrial Marketing and Purchasing (IMP) group, developed during the 1980s and was a pioneer in relational thought (Ford, 1980; Håkansson, 1982; Johanson and Mattsson, 1987; Håkansson and Snehota, 1995). With a focus on industrial markets, the IMP group conducted two main projects: IMP1, which studied dyadic B2B relationships and developed the interaction model, and IMP2, which studied networks of B2B relationships and developed the network approach (Håkansson, 1982). The second school of thought, the Nordic School of Services, emerged in the early 1980s, focusing on intangible products and services within both dyadic relationships and networks in B2B markets (Berry, 1983; Grönroos, 1994; Gummesson, 1994; Grönroos, 1997). This school developed the ideas of creating value with customers and fulfillment of promises in service marketing (Grönroos, 1990). Moreover, later research within this tradition developed the service-dominant logic (Vargo and Lusch, 2004) and further advanced the understanding of value co-creation in relationships (Heinonen et al., 2010; Edvardsson et al., 2008; Edvardsson et al., 2011).

The third school of thought, the Anglo-Australian School, developed in the early 1990s and extended the idea of relationships between businesses by emphasizing the role of relationships with stakeholders (Christopher et al., 1991). This school of thought introduced the six markets model (customer, referral, supplier, influence, recruitment, and internal markets) (Christopher et al., 1991). The fourth school of thought, the North American approach, also developed in the early to mid-1990s, focused primarily on dyadic relationships (Dwyer et al., 1987; Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995). While some scholars focused on B2B relationships and developed the commitment-trust theory (Morgan and Hunt, 1994) and the relationship development process model (Dwyer et al., 1987), others introduced the first

conceptual ideas of relational thought in B2C markets (Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Pels, 1999).

Although these four schools of thought differ slightly in focus and units of analysis, they share the above-mentioned assumptions; thus, RET serves as a theoretical umbrella that unites them. Central to these assumptions is the view that relationships function as mechanisms for reducing uncertainty (Ford, 1980; Dwyer et al., 1987; Wilson, 1995). While some schools of thought focus on dyadic relationships (Dwyer et al., 1987), others adopt a network approach (Håkansson, 1982), recognizing that uncertainty is not confined to the focal relationship, but is also shaped by other relationships within the broader business network. Nevertheless, the underlying logic remains the same: parties adapt to one another and invest in the relationship in an effort to reduce this uncertainty (Ford, 1980; Wilson, 1995).

Furthermore, there are different views on how RET applies to B2B and B2C markets for studying relationships. It is important to discuss both, as much of the theoretical foundation and contemporary understanding of B2C relationships has evolved from earlier studies of B2B relationships. This has consequently prompted a debate in the marketing literature on B2C relationships, with several studies arguing that B2B and B2C relationships differ fundamentally in nature (Gruen, 1995; Hunt, 2013; Safari and Albaum, 2019; Safari, 2026). These differences are important to understand, as they have direct implications for the theoretical foundation of this thesis. Accordingly, a discussion of B2B relationships is essential before turning to a more focused review of RET's adaptation and extension to B2C relationships. Therefore, the following section examines prior research on relationships in B2B markets and then discusses relationships in B2C markets.

Relationships in Business-to-Business Markets

Most of the intellectual development of RET has taken place within B2B markets, where the study of B2B relationships has been established for over four decades (Ford, 1980; Håkansson, 1982; Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Edvardsson et al., 2008; Schilke and Lumineau, 2025). According to these studies, B2B relationships involve economic, social, and informational exchanges, with active interaction between parties and a long-term orientation. These relationships are typically characterized by closeness, high adaptation, interdependence, heterogeneity, bounded rationality, low levels of opportunistic behavior, open communication, and the sharing of confidential information (Johanson and Mattsson, 1987; Hadjikhani and LaPlaca, 2013). Moreover, trust and commitment are widely recognized as fundamental to B2B relationships (Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Havila et al., 2004) because they help reduce uncertainty (Hadjikhani and LaPlaca, 2013). Uncertainty exists in any relationship, and relationships are interdependent; hence, parties rarely have complete information about each other's behavior and cannot fully predict future outcomes

(Wilson, 1995). This uncertainty often arises from limited information and concerns about opportunistic behavior (Morgan and Hunt, 1994). As a result, relationships develop under conditions in which trust and commitment are essential for reducing uncertainty (Ford and Mouzas, 2010; Schilke and Lumineau, 2025).

In this stream of research, various conceptualizations of B2B relationship development have been proposed (e.g., Ford, 1980; Dwyer et al., 1987; Larson, 1992; Evans and Laskin, 1994; Wilson, 1995; Batonda and Perry, 2003; Edvardsson et al., 2008). Across these streams, however, the models vary in their underlying conceptualizations, the terminology used to label the development phases, and the number of phases through which relationships are assumed to progress. Examples include Dwyer et al.'s (1987) five-phase model as awareness, exploration, expansion, commitment, and dissolution; Ford's (1980) five-stage model: pre-relationship stage, early stage, development stage, long-term stage, and final stage; Larson's (1992) three-phase model: preconditions for exchange history, conditions to build, and integration and control; Wilson's (1995) five-phase model: partner selection, defining purpose, setting relationship boundaries, creating relationship value, and relationship maintenance; and Batonda and Perry's (2003) five-stage model: relationship searching, relationship starting, relationship development, relationship maintenance, and relationship termination processes. In contrast to studies focusing on relationship development, some studies exclusively focus on the B2B relationship initiation process. Specifically, Edvardsson et al. (2008) propose a three-status model consisting of unrecognized, recognized, and considered status, after which a business agreement is reached and the relationship formally begins.

Furthermore, there are various definitions of trust and commitment among relational theorists studying B2B relationships. Regarding trust, some studies (e.g., Ford, 1980; Morgan and Hunt, 1994) adopt, with minor modifications, Moorman et al.'s (1993, p. 82) definition of trust as “a willingness to rely on an exchange partner in whom one has confidence.” Others (e.g., Dwyer et al., 1987) follow Blau's (1964, p. 940) definition, describing trust as “the belief that a party's word or promise is reliable and a party will fulfill his/her obligations in an exchange relationship.” Trust is also referred to as confidence in a partner, which is developed through repeated experiences (Håkansson, 1982). Regarding commitment, studies on B2B relationships often draw on the behavioral school (e.g., Cyert and March, 1963) and define commitment as investments made by parties in the relationship (Scholl, 1981; Håkansson, 1982; Hallén et al., 1991). Thus, some studies (e.g., Ford, 1980; Morgan and Hunt, 1994) adopt, with minor modifications, Moorman et al.'s (1992, p. 316) definition of commitment as “an enduring desire to maintain a valued relationship.” Others, such as Dwyer et al. (1987, p. 19), define commitment as “an implicit or explicit pledge of relational continuity between exchange partners.” In other words, although definitions vary, they converge on the view

that trust reflects confidence in a partner, whereas commitment represents investments in and maintenance of the relationship.

Apart from the different definitions of trust and commitment, there are also different views on their roles in B2B relationships. This variation is partly related to the existence of different types of B2B relationships, such as dyadic (Morgan and Hunt, 1994), triadic (Havila et al., 2004), and networked relationships (Håkansson, 1982; Safari, 2025). As such, these theories have not developed in isolation; rather, there is a long-standing tradition of borrowing and integrating concepts and ideas from other literatures. Some examples include the business network approach and the interaction model, which emphasize interdependence among parties within a business network and the business-supplier interaction, respectively (Håkansson, 1982; Ford, 1980; Håkansson and Snehota, 1995). These models draw on ideas from sociological (Granovetter, 1973) and behavioral theorists (Simon, 1947; Cyert and March, 1963) but modify them to the context of B2B industrial markets. Another example is the relationship development process model by Dwyer et al. (1987), which is a conceptual framework that extends beyond industrial markets and conceptualizes relationship development as a dynamic process unfolding through distinct phases. Their framework draws on multiple theoretical ideas, including relational contracting theory (Macneil, 1977), social exchange theory (e.g., Blau, 1964), and the distribution channel literature (e.g., Stern and Reve, 1980). As such, these relationship theories share a similar view of trust and commitment, viewing them as outcomes or goals of relationship development (Ford, 1980; Dwyer et al., 1987; Håkansson and Snehota, 1995). They argue that as parties interact, they move through distinct phases in which trust and commitment develop gradually over the course of the relationship. For instance, trust and commitment are typically at their lowest levels during the initial phase of a relationship. As the relationship progresses, these constructs gradually increase and eventually become the outcomes in the later phases. Once these two are developed, it signals that the relationship has fully matured. Therefore, trust and commitment are conceptualized as the goals of an evolving relationship (Ford, 1980; Dwyer et al., 1987; Håkansson and Snehota, 1995).

While the relationship models discussed above have been widely acknowledged in the marketing literature, the most recognized relationship model in B2B markets is the commitment-trust theory by Morgan and Hunt (1994). They draw on ideas from social exchange theory (e.g., Cook and Emerson, 1978), organization literature (e.g., Mowday et al., 1979; Meyer and Allen, 1984), and marriage literature (e.g., Thompson and Spanier, 1983). Morgan and Hunt (1994) view trust and commitment as a means to a goal, in which they act as mediators or mechanisms in developing any relationship (Morgan and Hunt, 1994). For instance, parties actively engage in activities aimed at strengthening trust and commitment, which in turn facilitate positive relational behaviors and outcomes. Trust and commitment are not the end goal in

the relationship per se; rather, they function as influential mechanisms that drive these positive outcomes and, in turn, foster a long-term, successful B2B relationship. In this regard, Morgan and Hunt (1994) conceptualize trust and commitment as key mediating constructs, each having their respective antecedents (i.e., relationship termination costs, relationship benefits, shared values, communication, opportunistic behavior) and outcomes (i.e., acquiescence, propensity to leave, cooperation, functional conflict, uncertainty). Moreover, they argue that parties are more likely to invest in the relationship when they trust their partner, conceptualizing trust as the antecedent of commitment. While these studies have contributed to a substantial body of knowledge on B2B relationships, their strong focus on B2B markets has also shaped the conceptualization of relationships.

As a result, it has been argued, both implicitly and explicitly, that any interaction that does not follow the same principles as B2B relationships cannot be considered a relationship (Barnes, 1994; O'Malley and Tynan, 2000; O'Malley, 2001; Leahy, 2011). Despite the longstanding debate over the applicability of relational thought in B2C markets, several studies have demonstrated the existence and relevance of B2C relationships (e.g., Gruen, 1995; Pels, 1999; Eastlick et al., 2006; Safari, 2026). Nevertheless, the general ideas of B2B relationships have been adopted in B2C markets, especially the concepts of trust and commitment (Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Pavlou et al., 2007; Safari and Albaum, 2019). Thus, several scholars have argued that relationships exist even in B2C markets.

Relationships in Business-to-Consumer Markets

The study of relationships in B2C markets began in the 1990s (Bagozzi, 1995; Gruen, 1995; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Pels, 1999). Over the years, scholars have developed a substantial body of knowledge on consumer relationships (De Wulf et al., 2001; Bhattacharya and Sen, 2003; Zhang et al., 2016; Connors et al., 2021; Safari, 2026), including insights into why consumers develop them. Sheth and Parvatiyar (1995) draw on the consumer behavior literature and argue that, in contrast to B2B markets, which view relationships as the end goal, consumers engage in relationships as a means of reducing choice. Pavlou et al. (2007) and Safari (2014) argue that consumers engage in relationships primarily to reduce uncertainty. Others suggest that consumers engage in relationships to access specific benefits (Palvia, 2009). While these explanations differ, none exclude the other; rather, they enrich the understanding of why consumers engage in relationships.

Previous studies have debated the nature of consumer relationships in marketing literature. While some argue that relationships in consumer markets are largely rhetoric (O'Malley and Tynan, 2000), others emphasize the strength of consumer relationships (Gruen, 1995; Safari, 2014; Safari and Albaum, 2019;

Safari, 2026). In doing so, they suggest that consumer relationships are both short- and long-term orientations, involving both high and low levels of adaptation and interdependency, allowing for mutuality as well as switching behavior due to varying levels of investment. Furthermore, such relationships may entail both direct and indirect interactions, heterogeneity, bounded rationality, and active participation (Gruen, 1995; Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 2000; Eastlick et al., 2006; Pavlou et al., 2007; Safari and Albaum, 2019). Moreover, studies have noted that studying B2C relationships is generally more challenging than studying B2B relationships, given their less structured and less formalized nature (Gruen, 1995; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Pels, 1999; Hadjikhani and LaPlaca, 2013). Specifically, consumer relationships differ in that they are largely voluntary, and consumers can freely enter and exit them (O'Malley and Tynan, 2001; Li et al., 2007; Safari and Albaum, 2019). In contrast, B2B relationships are typically constrained by contractual obligations and mutual interdependence (Ford, 1980; Håkansson and Snehota, 1995).

Thus, several studies have highlighted the differences between relationships in B2C and B2B markets (e.g., Gruen, 1995; Bennett, 1996; Hunt, 2013; Safari and Albaum, 2019; Safari, 2026). According to these studies, the differences include several aspects. First, *the nature of the market* differs: B2B markets involve fewer buyers, whereas B2C markets operate on a much larger scale. To overcome this, consumer segmentation occurs in B2C markets. Second, *the relationship form* varies: B2B relationships occur between firms, such as buyer-supplier relationships, working alliances, distribution channel relationships, and partnerships, whereas B2C relationships exist between firms and end consumers. Third, *interaction* differs: in B2B markets, direct interaction occurs because of the limited number of buyers. In B2C markets, both direct and indirect interactions take place. However, technological advances have partly addressed this limitation, as contemporary studies (e.g., Wang et al., 2016; Cui et al., 2020) show that technology not only increases direct interaction but also plays a fundamental role in value creation and customer retention. Fourth, *the level of investment* differs: B2B relationships involve substantial financial investments, such as machinery or equipment, while B2C relationships generally involve lower investments of time and money. Fifth, *switching costs and behavior* vary because of the level of investment. Switching costs are relatively low in B2C markets, which makes it easier for consumers to switch to alternative sellers. In B2B markets, switching is far more costly as it entails stronger financial consequences. Sixth, *orientation* differs due to the varying levels of investment in B2B and B2C markets. While there is a long-term orientation in B2B, in B2C markets, both long- and short-term orientations coexist. Finally, *adaptation* varies: B2B relationships tend to show high adaptation, whereas high and low adaptation can coexist in B2C relationships. Based on the above, while B2C relationships share several characteristics with B2B relationships, the most significant difference is that they

typically involve lower levels of investment. This, in turn, leads to a higher propensity for consumers to switch between sellers.

When consumer relationships came to be understood as being different from B2B, some scholars began to adopt and modify B2B relationship theories, such as the IMP Group's network approach (Håkansson, 1982; Håkansson and Snehota, 1995), for application in B2C markets (e.g., Pels, 1999). Moreover, Morgan and Hunt's (1994) commitment-trust theory emerged as the most widely adopted framework and has had a lasting influence on the conceptualization of B2C relationships (e.g., Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Wang et al., 2016; Cui et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2023). As such, numerous influential studies have built on these ideas, shaping the B2C relationship literature over the decades (e.g., Gruen, 1995; Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007). For example, Gruen (1995) modified Morgan and Hunt's (1994) ideas to B2C contexts and developed a model for studying B2C relationships. Similarly, Eastlick et al. (2006) and Mukherjee and Nath (2007) adopted the commitment-trust theory in B2C contexts and examined its implications for consumer relationship outcomes. These studies have formed the foundation for much contemporary research, which borrows and modifies the theoretical concepts of trust and commitment to understand consumer relationships; however, primarily in low-uncertainty contexts (Li et al., 2006; Li et al., 2007; Wang et al., 2016; Cui et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2023).

This adaptation, however, was neither straightforward nor without criticism. One criticism was that applying B2B relationship theories to B2C markets is theoretically problematic because B2C markets are inherently transactional, mass markets, characterized by anonymity, large numbers of buyers, lower levels of investment, and a higher propensity for switching (Li et al., 2007; Safari and Albaum, 2019). The applicability of trust and commitment concepts to B2C contexts seemed problematic, since these concepts were originally grounded in B2B settings, which are characterized by closeness, interpersonal interaction, and high levels of investment (Gruen, 1995; O'Malley and Tynan, 2001). For example, commitment in B2B relationships has traditionally been associated with high levels of investment, such as a firm's financial investment in machinery and equipment (Safari and Albaum, 2019). In contrast, such relationship-specific investments are largely absent in B2C markets, where exchanges typically involve lower financial investments (Leahy, 2011; O'Malley and Tynan, 2000). As a result, the level of commitment in B2C relationships was considered relatively low, which prompted criticism regarding the relevance of commitment as a meaningful concept in consumer markets (O'Malley and Tynan, 2000; O'Malley and Tynan, 2001). Similar concerns were raised about the applicability of the concept of trust. In B2B relationships, trust typically develops through repeated interactions between identifiable partners, shaped by adaptations, accumulated experiences, and long-term cooperation (Johanson and Mattsson, 1987; Morgan and Hunt,

1994). In contrast, B2C markets are characterized by anonymity and limited direct interaction, which reduces opportunities for trust to develop. Consequently, trust was often viewed as less relevant in consumer markets, where exchanges were assumed to be determined by the price mechanism rather than relational mechanisms (O'Malley and Tynan, 2000; Berg, 2022).

Another criticism questioned whether consumers and businesses even *wanted* a relationship (Noble and Philips, 2004). Many businesses consistently used the 4Ps marketing mix (Noble and Philips, 2004) and distributed their offerings through middlemen, limiting direct interaction with consumers (Berg, 2022). This reinforced a transactional view of B2C markets. Some scholars, nevertheless, eventually began to challenge these criticisms (Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Pels, 1999). They argued that technological advancements enabled relationship marketing in consumer markets through direct and database marketing (Sheth and Parvatiyar, 2000; O'Malley and Tynan, 2001; Palmer et al., 2005). These approaches could enable firms to track consumer data, personalize offerings, enhance direct interactions, and better adapt to relevant consumers (Dwyer et al., 1987; Blattberg and Deighton, 1991; Pavlou et al., 2007). While this perspective highlighted new relational opportunities in B2C markets, it also faced resistance. Some questioned whether technology could truly support the development of psychological aspects such as trust and commitment, arguing that these approaches lacked interpersonal interaction (Barnes, 2001) and emotional bonds (Leahy, 2011). Others raised concerns about consumer privacy (Cespedes and Smith, 1993; Goodwin, 1991; Jones, 1991; Wang and Petrison, 1993). Some also argued that database-driven strategies might hinder relationship development by prioritizing consumer acquisition rather than supporting ongoing exchange (Barnes, 2001).

As these examples illustrate, relational thought in B2C markets has faced considerable debate and criticism for decades. Much of this skepticism stems from the dominance of transactional thinking in consumer markets and doubts about whether relational concepts such as trust and commitment are applicable beyond B2B contexts. Given this critique, relational thought in B2C markets has not been straightforward. As noted in his conceptual paper, Gruen (1995, p. 449) observes that "relationship marketing research has generally neglected consumer markets" and draws on Sheth (1994), who argues that, "contrary to academic belief, relational exchange is not limited to institutional markets, but is equally prevalent in consumer markets."

Despite the strong historical resistance to relational thought in B2C markets, scholars have long argued for the relevance of B2C relationships, as consumers want to simplify their choices, increase efficiency and reduce uncertainty (Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Gruen, 1995; Fournier, 1998; Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Hadjikhani and Bengtson, 2006; Safari and Albaum, 2019; Safari, 2026). Collectively, prior research suggests that relationships in B2C markets differ in important ways from those examined in B2B markets

(Gruen, 1995; Hunt, 2013; Safari and Albaum, 2019). These differences have shaped contemporary research, as scholars increasingly recognize the distinct nature of consumer markets and modify ideas developed in B2B relationship research when examining B2C relationships (Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Pavlou et al., 2007). As a consequence, this has also led to various definitions of uncertainty, trust, and commitment. Drawing on the principal-agent perspective, Pavlou et al. (2007, p. 107) define uncertainty as "the degree to which the outcome of a transaction cannot be accurately predicted by the buyer due to seller and product related factors." Mou et al. (2020b, p. 406) build on this definition and define uncertainty as "the degree to which the outcome of a transaction may not be accurately performed for the buyer." Another definition is provided by Sun et al. (2022, p. 2), who draw on Pfeffer and Salancik (1978) and state that "Uncertainty refers to the extent to which future events cannot be accurately predicted." Despite these differences, the definitions converge on the idea that uncertainty is associated with the difficulty consumers face in predicting future outcomes.

There are also different definitions of trust and commitment in the literature. For trust, some scholars define it as "the buyer's intentions to accept vulnerability based on her beliefs that the transaction will meet her confident expectations" (Pavlou et al., 2007, p. 107). Based on consumer behavior literature (e.g., Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995), Gruen (1995, p. 455) defines trust as "a level of confidence that the other party's expected behavior will result in valued outcomes." Moreover, several studies have discussed the multidimensionality of trust (McKnight and Chervany, 2001; Gefen et al., 2003; Wang et al., 2016). While various dimensions have been discussed, the most commonly identified are benevolence, integrity, and competence (McKnight and Chervany, 2001; McKnight et al., 2002; Pavlou et al., 2007; Palvia, 2009; Tam et al., 2020). Accordingly, trust is widely understood as a multidimensional concept in which consumers expect sellers not to engage in opportunistic behavior.

Commitment has also been defined in various ways within the literature. A recurrent approach to defining consumers' commitment to a retailer has been to adopt and modify definitions from organizational studies of employees' commitment to their organizations (Garbarino and Johnson, 1999). As such, drawing on organizational research (e.g., Scholl, 1981), Gruen (1995) defines commitment as "a motivational force that acts to maintain behavioral direction" (p. 454). The study by Eastlick et al. (2006) also draws on organizational studies (e.g., Mowday et al., 1979) and defines commitment as consumers' willingness to maintain interactions with a retailer, including supporting, recommending, and choosing to purchase from that retailer over other alternatives. Other scholars, such as Wang et al. (2016, p. 629), draw on Morgan and Hunt (1994), arguing that "relationship commitment is one entity's belief that its ongoing relationship with another entity is important and beneficial, and thus that it is worth making a significant effort to ensure

the continuance of this relationship indefinitely." Similarly, Lin et al. (2023, p. 1131) state that "relationship commitment refers to the efforts of the two parties to sustain their business relationship, as both believe in its importance and value." In other words, although these definitions vary slightly, they converge on the view that commitment reflects consumers' investments to continue the relationship.

Furthermore, similar to B2B relationships unfolding through different phases (Ford, 1980; Dwyer et al., 1987; Wilson, 1995), prior research has also argued that consumer relationships develop across distinct phases (Fournier, 1998; Wang et al., 2000; Campbell et al., 2009; Campbell, 2019). For example, Fournier (1998) proposes a five-phase model comprising initiation, growth, maintenance, deterioration, and dissolution. Similarly, Campbell et al. (2009) and Campbell (2019) developed a three-phase model encompassing attraction, build-up, and continuance. Both of these studies draw on stage theory from social psychology (Levinger, 1980), which conceptualizes relationships as progressing through stages such as initial attraction, relationship building, continuation, deterioration, and ending. Other scholars, such as Wang et al. (2000), propose a three-stage model comprising an initial investigation, full-range communication, and relationship network creation. In other words, consumer relationship development has been conceptualized in multiple ways, with models differing in both the labels used and the number of phases proposed. Although these models provide valuable insights into how consumer relationships unfold, they have been developed exclusively to understand consumer relationship development in low-uncertainty contexts. Hence, they offer a limited understanding of consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts, as the nature of these contexts differs fundamentally from one another (Lee et al., 2026).

Theoretical Positioning of the Thesis

RET has undergone extensive development, resulting in substantial scholarly contributions. However, this body of knowledge is predominantly derived from low-uncertainty contexts, with very limited research examining its applicability in high-uncertainty contexts. This thesis, therefore, draws on RET to examine and enhance the understanding of consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts. In doing so, it extends RET beyond the conditions under which it has primarily been developed and validated. Accordingly, it is necessary to clarify the theoretical positioning of this thesis within this body of research.

First, in line with its aim, this thesis draws primarily on insights from research on relationships in B2C markets (Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Gruen, 1995; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Eastlick et al., 2006; Pavlou et al., 2007; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007). Although research on B2B relationships offers

important insights (Ford, 1980; Dwyer et al., 1987; Johanson and Mattsson, 1987; Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Wilson, 1995), prior research demonstrates that B2B and B2C relationships differ fundamentally (Gruen, 1995; Hunt, 2013; Safari and Albaum, 2019). This thesis, therefore, adopts B2C relationship research as the most theoretically appropriate basis for examining consumer relationship development.

Second, this thesis adopts uncertainty, trust, and commitment as its core theoretical concepts. While RET encompasses multiple concepts for studying relationships, these three are consistently supported both theoretically and empirically (Dwyer et al., 1987; Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Gruen, 1995; Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Pavlou et al., 2007; Cui et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2023). At the same time, this body of research is largely grounded in low-uncertainty contexts, which differ fundamentally from high-uncertainty contexts (Lee et al., 2026). Following the same logic through which B2C relationship research adapted concepts originally developed in B2B markets, this thesis argues that insights derived from low-uncertainty contexts are unlikely to translate directly to high-uncertainty contexts without modification. Consequently, relationship development can be expected to differ under such conditions. Accordingly, while this thesis draws on trust, commitment, and uncertainty from prior research, it adopts an open theoretical stance to account for these differences.

Despite this openness, theoretical development requires a clear starting point. This thesis, therefore, adopts established conceptualizations while allowing for their refinement. Uncertainty is defined, following Pavlou et al. (2007, p. 107), as "the degree to which the outcome of a transaction cannot be accurately predicted by the buyer due to seller and product related factors." However, rather than restricting uncertainty to these sources, this thesis acknowledges that in high-uncertainty contexts, it may arise from a broader set of sources, while retaining its core meaning as the difficulty of anticipating outcomes. Trust is defined as "the buyer's intentions to accept vulnerability based on her beliefs that the transaction will meet her confident expectations" (Pavlou et al., 2007, p. 107). Commitment, following Eastlick et al. (2006), refers to consumers' willingness to maintain interactions with a retailer, including supporting, recommending, and choosing to purchase from that retailer over other alternatives. These definitions and conceptualizations are adopted because they are well established in B2C relationship research and provide theoretical guidance for examining relationship development under high uncertainty.

Third, this thesis conceptualizes consumer relationship development as unfolding across distinct phases. A phase-based perspective is particularly suitable because it enables a nuanced understanding of the roles of uncertainty, trust, and commitment both across and within phases, including how different types of uncertainty emerge and shape development. Accordingly, prior RET research shows that relationship development occurs in phases in both B2B

(Ford, 1980; Dwyer et al., 1987; Larson, 1992; Evans and Laskin, 1994; Wilson, 1995; Batonda and Perry, 2003) and B2C markets (Fournier, 1998; Wang et al., 2000; Campbell et al., 2009; Campbell, 2019). While these studies have focused primarily on low-uncertainty contexts, the labeling and structure of these phases differ both *between* and *within* B2B and B2C markets. In B2B research, for example, Dwyer et al. (1987) propose five phases, Larson (1992) identifies three phases, and Wilson (1995) outlines five phases using different labels. Similarly, in B2C research, Fournier (1998) proposes five phases, whereas Campbell et al. (2009), Campbell (2019), and Wang et al. (2000) identify three phases, each with distinct labels. Building on this stream of research, this thesis adopts a phase-based perspective to examine consumer relationship development. At the same time, given the variation in prior research and the nature of high-uncertainty contexts, this thesis maintains theoretical flexibility and treats this variation as theoretically informative for understanding how relationship development unfolds. Hence, this thesis allows the number and labeling of phases to be identified and refined during the research process,[5] as it is important to account for the nature of high-uncertainty contexts.

Finally, RET offers no clear definition of what constitutes a "relationship," and scholars have explicitly noted the difficulty of defining it (e.g., see Huston and Burgess, 1979; Huston and Robins, 1982; Snehota and Håkansson, 1995; Blocker et al., 2012; Hadjikhani and LaPlaca, 2013). Instead, the RET literature has largely relied on the characteristics of relationships to approximate their meaning (Dwyer et al., 1987; Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Gruen, 1995; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Eastlick et al., 2006). This thesis follows this line of thought and draws on these characteristics to specify what a relationship entails. Accordingly, in this thesis, a consumer relationship refers to the development of trust and commitment by consumers to reduce uncertainty in high-uncertainty contexts. This formulation is adopted because it aligns with the core theoretical mechanisms of RET (Dwyer et al., 1987; Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Wilson, 1995) and reflects how relationships are characterized in prior B2C research (Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Gruen, 1995; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Eastlick et al., 2006; Pavlou et al., 2007; Cui et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2023), while explicitly incorporating the central role of uncertainty.

Based on the above, these theoretical considerations form the starting point of this thesis to study consumer relationship development under heightened uncertainty. They provide the basis for extending RET beyond its established boundaries while also increasing understanding of consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts.

[5] The phases developed in this thesis are presented and discussed in the discussion (Chapter 5).

3. Method

Research Context

This thesis aims to study and increase understanding of consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts. To achieve this aim, it uses cross-border e-commerce (CBEC) as an empirical illustration of such a context. In CBEC, defined as online trade between consumers and retailers across national borders, consumers can purchase from different types of retailers (Huang and Chang, 2019; Xu et al., 2025). Within this context, the thesis focuses on a specific type of retailer with which consumers can develop relationships, namely small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) that adopt a cost-effective approach, replicating their home-country website for a host-country website to target consumers in that host country. Some scholars describe this approach as "an internationalization step of an online retailer as the launch of a country-specific website" (Schu and Morschett, 2017, p. 717) and label it as a partial online internationalization retailer (hereinafter POI-retailer) (Safari and Yamin, 2016). A POI-retailer is a smaller retailer that, due to resource constraints, makes partial investments in CBEC to target consumers in a specific country. More specifically, they develop a country-specific website characterized by country-specific language, domain name, unique resource locators (e.g., ".se" for Sweden), and currency (e.g., SEK) to target consumers in a host country (e.g., see Kotha et al., 2001; Daryanto et al., 2016; Safari and Yamin, 2016; Schu and Morschett, 2017; Swoboda and Sinning, 2022; Mueller and Swoboda, 2025). Studying consumer relationships with POI retailers in CBEC, which represents a high-uncertainty context in this thesis, offers an optimal and timely research setting for several reasons.

Firstly, recent reports suggest that the B2C CBEC industry will witness an exceptional growth in the coming years, with current forecasts predicting an increase from 785 billion U.S. dollars in 2021 to over 7.9 trillion U.S. dollars by 2030 (Statista, 2024). In comparison, the global economy was assessed at 98.2 trillion U.S. dollars in 2021 and is predicted to reach 142.6 trillion U.S. dollars by 2029 (Statista, 2026a). Based on these recent reports, it is estimated that by 2030, the B2C CBEC industry will account for nearly six percent of the global economy. This highlights, on the one hand, that consumers and retailers are increasingly recognizing the meaningful opportunities in CBEC. On the other hand, what was once non-existent in the past has, in the present era, evolved into a key driver of global retail growth and, more importantly, a

major backbone of the global economy. Therefore, CBEC is a suitable industry to study, and scientific inquiry is of the utmost importance for a better understanding of this growing phenomenon.

Secondly, by its very nature, purchasing in CBEC involves uncertainty, as consumers purchase from retailers located across national borders (Mou et al., 2020b). Beyond the inherent limitations of online purchasing, such as the inability to physically inspect products or interact directly with the retailer, this setting amplifies uncertainty due to cross-border characteristics, stemming from language barriers, differing legal systems, overseas product shipments, and payment security (Huang and Chang, 2019; Safari and Yamin, 2016; Lee and Xiong, 2026; Lee et al., 2026). While these factors collectively make it challenging for consumers to purchase with confidence, purchasing specifically from POI-retailers in CBEC introduces an additional layer of uncertainty, making it even more pronounced. Unlike large, well-known retailers that invest heavily in reducing uncertainty (primarily through their well-known brand name), POI-retailers often lack such resources, and consumers remain unfamiliar with them. POI-retailers' limited ability to signal reliability, together with the inherent uncertainty of CBEC, intensifies consumers' uncertainty, making this empirical context highly uncertain for them.

Lastly, while the chosen empirical context should be generalized with caution, this thesis argues that it provides important insights for practitioners at smaller, resource-constrained retailers using a POI approach in CBEC. According to the World Bank (2022), small retailers are particularly important, as they represent the backbone of the global economy. However, they remain underrepresented in CBEC, as recent reports indicate that approximately seventy-three percent of consumers purchase from large, well-known multinational online retailers (e.g., Amazon, Shein, and Zalando) (Statista, 2026b). This highlights the dominant position of large retailers, which places smaller retailers at a disadvantage in the CBEC industry and underscores the need to support them.

This research context is thus not only relevant for increasing theoretical understanding of consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts but is also crucial for helping foreign, smaller, less-branded online retailers in CBEC. Consequently, this can contribute to sustainable, long-term growth in the CBEC industry, thereby supporting the broader global economy.

Research Design

This thesis consists of four papers based on three studies: Study 1 for Paper I; Study 2 for Papers II and III; and Study 3, comprising three sub-studies (3a, 3b, and 3c), for Paper IV. The research design of this thesis is grounded in a multiphase approach and is based on a mixed-methods strategy, using both quantitative and qualitative methods (Tashakkori and Teddlie, 2003;

Tashakkori and Teddlie, 2010). Moreover, abductive reasoning is adopted, as it enables an iterative interplay between data and theory (Sætre and Van de Ven, 2021) and is particularly suitable given the limited theoretical understanding of consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts. Unlike the traditional exploratory-explicatory-confirmatory multiphase order (Tashakkori and Teddlie, 1998), this thesis follows an exploratory-confirmatory-explicatory order. This alternative order emerged organically throughout the research process, as each step was shaped by the findings and methodological requirements that arose along the way. A summary of the research design is presented in Table 1, followed by a detailed explanation of the research design for each study.

Table 1. Summary of the Research Design

Multiphase	Study	Papers	Research method	Data sources	Main data analysis
Exploratory	1	I	Quantitative and qualitative, systematic literature review	81 peer-reviewed articles	Bibliometric analysis (i.e., bibliometric performance, conceptual thematic map, and bibliographic coupling) and content analysis
Confirmatory	2	II and III	Quantitative, questionnaire	364 respondents	Structural equation modeling, mediation analysis
Explicatory	3 (3a, 3b, 3c)	IV	Qualitative, in-depth, semi-structured interviews	60 participants (20 per sub-study)	Gioia methodology, comparative analysis

Study 1

In the exploratory phase, this thesis began developing Study 1 for Paper I in 2022. This paper focused on understanding prior research on consumer behavior in CBEC. Using a hybrid systematic literature review (SLR), it combined qualitative content analysis and quantitative bibliometric analysis to map established research streams and identify underdeveloped areas. The paper synthesizes prior research to develop a framework for consumer behavior in CBEC and identifies future research directions. Three of these directions directly guided the subsequent papers in this thesis. First, prior research on CBEC has largely focused on short-term outcomes of the purchasing journey, with limited attention to long-term outcomes such as consumer relationship development. Second, the review revealed that consumers can purchase from three types of retailers in CBEC, but the literature has predominantly focused on two of these types, with limited attention to POI-retailers. Third, CBEC, as a purchasing context, presents substantial uncertainty across multiple sources (i.e., website, retailer, product, purchasing, post-purchasing, and relationships) and across different phases of the CBEC journey. However, these

uncertainties and their implications for consumer relationship development remain largely underexplored. Consequently, the findings of Paper I shaped the design of the subsequent papers in this thesis and served as a springboard for the following studies.

Moreover, given the limited number of studies examining consumer purchasing from POI-retailers in CBEC, it was necessary to gain a deeper understanding of this research context, specifically what it entails for consumers navigating in high-uncertainty contexts. To address this, an exploratory pre-study was conducted comprising five in-depth interviews with three CEOs of POI-retailers from Sweden, all operating in the retail industry and targeting consumers in different foreign markets. To clarify, this exploratory pre-study was not used as empirical data in any of the papers; instead, it served to deepen an understanding of what constitutes a high-uncertainty context. Hence, this pre-study functioned as a preparatory step rather than as a standalone study. Based on prior definitions of POI-retailers (Schu and Morschett, 2017; Sinning and Swoboda, 2022), this thesis identified these POI-retailers using the Retriever Business database and a search approach similar to that used in previous studies (Hånell et al., 2020). The interviews, which lasted between 65 and 85 minutes each, revealed that POI-retailers, as small businesses, face several challenges in approaching consumers and developing long-term relationships. These challenges include limited financial resources, low brand recognition, and difficulties in signaling credibility to consumers in CBEC. In addition, operating across national borders entails language barriers and cultural differences, which, together with consumer unfamiliarity with the retailer, further intensify the challenges of developing relationships with consumers. The interviews indicated that the companies were interested in gaining insight into how consumers could evolve beyond a single purchase to develop a relationship. Building on insights from the exploratory phase, this thesis moved directly to the confirmatory phase.

Study 2

In the confirmatory phase, this thesis developed Study 2 in 2022 using a quantitative method, which underpins Papers II and III. This study focused specifically on the initial phase of the consumer relationship to understand the moment consumers first engage in high-uncertainty contexts and what types of uncertainty affect this phase. By adopting established theoretical concepts from the literature, the study also helped clarify whether RET's theoretical ideas, developed in prior research in low-uncertainty contexts, hold in high-uncertainty contexts. More specifically, it investigated whether the initial phase of consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts follows a similar path as found in previous studies.

Accordingly, a questionnaire was developed based on the constructs of trust, commitment, attitude, uncertainty (i.e., product and retailer uncertainty),

perceived ease of use, perceived usefulness (i.e., website uncertainty), and purchase intention. To examine the initial phase of relationship development, consumer purchase intention was treated as the dependent variable in both Papers II and III, with the remaining constructs serving as independent variables. All construct measurements were obtained from previously validated scales (see Table 4 for operationalization). In line with previous studies (Huang and Chang, 2019), a seven-point Likert scale was used to measure the items, where 1 = strongly disagree and 7 = strongly agree. Paper II focused on website-related uncertainty (i.e., perceived ease of use and perceived usefulness), as well as the concepts of trust and commitment, and their effects on purchase intention. Paper III focused on retailer- and product-related uncertainty, as well as the concepts of attitude, trust, and commitment, and their influence on purchase intention. The results of both papers, however, revealed surprising findings. The initial phase of relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts differs from both theory and previous research. This theoretical puzzle, along with the insights it yielded, consequently shaped the direction and design of the final study in the explicatory phase.

Study 3 (3a, 3b, 3c)

In the explicatory phase, this thesis conducted Study 3 in 2025, consisting of three sub-studies (3a, 3b, and 3c) using a qualitative method, which underpin Paper IV. Three different semi-structured interview guides were created, one for each sub-study. The focus of Study 3 was to understand the trajectory of relationship development, from initial contact to the point at which consumers have developed a relationship in a high-uncertainty context. In doing so, this thesis conducted three sub-studies to gain an in-depth understanding of each phase of the relationship development. This enabled the thesis to explain how consumers develop relationships, progress through each phase of development, and identify additional types of uncertainty that may hamper consumers' ability to develop relationships. In Study 3a, respondents were exposed to an unfamiliar POI-retailer to capture their initial perceptions, thoughts, and behaviors. Three pre-selected retailers from France, the United States, and China were identified beforehand. The criteria for identifying a POI-retailer were informed by prior research, which is discussed in depth below (e.g., Safari and Yamin, 2016; Schu and Morschett, 2017). Participants were then free to choose one of these retailers to explore in more detail.

Study 3b included participants with one to three purchase experiences at a POI-retailer of their choice. This enabled the examination of early evaluation processes, both before and after purchase, and their implications for future interactions. Study 3c focused on participants who had established relationships with POI-retailers of their own choice, exploring how and why these relationships developed and, in some cases, why they were later terminated. By designing Study 3 as three sub-studies, Paper IV offers both overarching

and phase-specific insights into consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts. Moreover, Paper IV helped unpack the deviations from RET identified in Papers II and III while empirically assessing the ideas developed in Paper I.

Pre-selecting Retailers in High-Uncertainty Contexts for Study 2 and Study 3a

Based on the preceding discussion, this thesis uses POI-retailers in CBEC as the empirical research setting as a high-uncertainty context. In Study 2 and Study 3a, the focus was on understanding consumers' first contact with a POI-retailer under conditions of heightened uncertainty. It was therefore essential to ensure that participants had no prior experience with the selected POI-retailers, so that their responses would reflect a genuinely high-uncertainty context. This methodological choice was informed by the findings of Paper I, which showed that consumers can purchase from different types of retailers in CBEC and may thus develop relationships in both low- and high-uncertainty contexts. Allowing participants to freely select any unfamiliar retailer without further control could have compromised validity, as it would have been difficult to ensure that relationship development was examined specifically within a high-uncertainty context. Accordingly, to align the empirical context with conditions of heightened uncertainty, this thesis deliberately preselected several POI-retailers in Study 2 (Papers II and III) and Study 3a (Paper IV) prior to data collection. Based on theoretical sampling and drawing on previous studies that have identified several information cues influencing consumer uncertainty (e.g., Harrison-Walker, 2002; Mou et al., 2020a; Sharma and Klein, 2025), the following criteria were used to identify POI-retailers:

(I) The retailer was required to have a country-specific website with a country-specific language, domain name, and currency, which are characteristic features of POI-retailers (Schu and Morschett, 2017; Swoboda and Sinning, 2022). This criterion was intended to reduce familiarity with and increase ambiguity in website- and country-related cues (Harrison-Walker, 2002; Gefen et al., 2003; Huang and Chang, 2019; Sharma and Klein, 2025), as POI-retailers' websites often rely on low-effort design and translation due to resource constraints (Daryanto et al., 2013).

(II) The retailer was required to be physically located in a foreign country and not operate a warehouse in the host country. This criterion was set for two reasons. First, it ensured that products were shipped across national borders, so the purchasing context reflected CBEC

rather than domestic e-commerce (Mou et al., 2020b). Second, it limited consumers' access to product- and country-related cues, as such cues are less transparent and more difficult to evaluate in CBEC (Huang and Chang, 2019; Zhu et al., 2019; Mou et al., 2020a; Sun et al., 2022).

(III) The retailer was required to be a small, resource-constrained firm (i.e., a small or medium-sized enterprise) without a well-known brand name. This criterion was set to reduce the availability of seller-related cues, thereby limiting familiarity when evaluating the retailer (Gefen, 2000; Eastlick et al., 2006; Sharma and Klein, 2025). Such unfamiliarity is a core characteristic of POI-retailers and contributes to high uncertainty for consumers (Safari and Yamin, 2016).

Based on these criteria, four real-life POI-retailers were selected: one for Study 2 and three for Study 3a. For Study 2, a POI-retailer from Germany was selected for the quantitative study. For Study 3a, three POI-retailers were selected for the qualitative study, with one retailer from each of the following countries: France, the United States, and China. All selected POI-retailers in Studies 2 and 3a operate in the retail industry and sell consumer products online across national borders. Accordingly, all retailers operated Swedish-language websites with a Swedish domain name and currency (criterion I), were physically located in a foreign country (i.e., Germany/France/the United States/China) with products shipped to consumers in Sweden (criterion II), and were classified as SMEs without an established or well-known brand name, thus making them unfamiliar to respondents (criterion III). This thesis followed the European Commission's (2005) definition of an SME, which includes firms with fewer than 250 employees and an annual turnover of less than €50 million. Moreover, to further ensure that respondents were unfamiliar with the pre-selected POI-retailers, respondents in both studies (Studies 2 and 3a) were asked to confirm that they had not previously encountered the pre-selected POI-retailers.

Sample and Data Collection

The empirical data for this thesis were collected across three studies and form the basis for four papers. Study 1 informs Paper I; Study 2 underpins Papers II and III; and Study 3 comprises three sub-studies (3a, 3b, and 3c) for Paper IV. These three studies draw on multiple data sources, including peer-reviewed journal articles, questionnaire-based quantitative data, and in-depth semi-structured interviews. This thesis followed previous studies (Pavlou et al., 2007; Huang and Chang, 2019; Cui et al., 2020; Zerbini et al., 2022) and

hence targeted consumers with online purchasing experience (for Studies 2 and 3), as such experience provides a necessary basis for engaging with and evaluating online purchasing contexts. Accordingly, this thesis draws on data from Swedish consumers in Study 2 and Study 3 (3a, 3b, 3c). Sweden provides a suitable empirical context, as online purchasing is highly prevalent, with 86 percent of consumers having experience with it (Statista, 2025). This suggests that Swedish consumers can provide relevant insights into cross-border online purchasing. Respondents lacking such experience would therefore be unable to meaningfully contribute to a study of consumer relationship development in CBEC with POI-retailers (i.e., a high-uncertainty context) and thus fall outside the scope of this thesis.

Study 1

Study 1 (Paper I) was based on 81 peer-reviewed articles retrieved from multiple databases. In this study, a hybrid approach was adopted, combining qualitative content analysis and quantitative bibliometric analysis. Scopus and Web of Science (WoS) were selected primarily for their ability to support structured data extraction for bibliometric analysis and for their comprehensive coverage of eligible documents (e.g., Aria and Cuccurullo, 2017; Donthu et al., 2021; Lim et al., 2024). Study 1 used the Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses (PRISMA) protocol, following its four core steps (identification, screening, eligibility, and inclusion) to systematically identify relevant articles (Page et al., 2021).

In the first step, identification, several keywords were developed. Following prior literature review studies (Casprini et al., 2020), a systematic search strategy was employed to precisely identify relevant documents. To account for variation in terminology, several synonyms related to consumer behavior in CBEC were included, as scholars often use different terms (Hazarika and Mousavi, 2021). Keywords were structured using central parentheses and their associated synonyms. For example, rather than using "cross-border e-commerce" as a single keyword, "cross-border" and "e-commerce" were treated as separate keywords. In addition, a truncation technique was applied by incorporating an asterisk (*) to capture different variations of the keywords. Based on this approach, the following keyword search strategy was used: (("consumer*" OR "customer*") AND ("cross-border" OR "international" OR "foreign" OR "global*" OR "worldwide" OR "oversea*") AND ("e-commerce" OR "electronic commerce" OR "internet" OR "digital*" OR "online" OR "web" OR "website*" OR "site*" OR "retail*") AND ("purchas*" OR "buy*" OR "shop*" OR "intent*" OR "behavio*" OR "decision*")). This resulted in 6,343 articles, of which 4,600 were from Scopus and 1,743 from WoS.

The screening step consisted of two sub-steps. In the first screening, results were filtered based on the following criteria: the language was English; the document type was an article; and the subject area was related to Business,

Management and Accounting, Computer Science, Psychology, and Social Science. This yielded 2,672 articles, of which 1,742 were from Scopus and 930 from WoS. In the second screening, each retained article was thoroughly evaluated by reading the title, abstract, and keywords, and, when necessary, the full article. After the second screening, 2,551 articles were excluded based on the following criteria: (1) the study did not focus on consumer behavior in CBEC, and (2) the paper was purely conceptual (i.e., it contained no quantitative or qualitative data). This was because they either focused on (a) domestic e-commerce, (b) B2B CBEC, (c) cross-country/cultural comparisons in domestic e-commerce, or (d) foreign products purchased from a domestic online retailer.

This process resulted in 121 articles, of which 61 were from Scopus and 60 from WoS. In the final steps, the eligibility and inclusion steps, the 121 articles identified across the two databases were merged, and 37 duplicate articles were removed. All remaining articles were then reviewed to assess their eligibility and suitability for analysis, resulting in the exclusion of three studies that were not directly related to consumer behavior in CBEC. Table 2 presents the final, and hence total, sample for Study 1 in Paper I. It comprises 81 peer-reviewed articles published between 2005 and 2024 across 53 journals, with an average publication age of 3.85 years, an average of 21.40 citations per article, and a total of 4,791 references.

Table 2. Description of the Sample for Study 1

Description	Results
Timespan	2005:2024
Total number of articles	81
Sources (journals)	53
Average years from publication	3.85
Average citations per article	21.40
References	4,791

Study 2

Study 2 (Papers II and III) used a questionnaire to collect quantitative data. The data were collected from Swedish-speaking consumers in Sweden, as they are known to have a high level of online purchasing experience (Statista, 2025). Swedish consumers were particularly relevant because the pre-selected retailer was a German retailer based in Germany that had developed a Swedish-language website targeting consumers in Sweden. Respondents were recruited through online channels. This approach was adopted because respondents who use the Internet typically have online experience and, as prior research shows, are more likely to have experience with online purchasing (Huang and Chang, 2019; Zerbini et al., 2022). Furthermore, respondents were

informed that the study was conducted for academic purposes, that participation was voluntary, and that they could withdraw at any time. Anonymity was ensured by not retaining any identifying information. After respondents provided consent, they were instructed to complete two steps.

In the first step, it was important to ensure that respondents had no prior experience or familiarity with the pre-selected retailer or its website. This was important for establishing the prerequisites for a high-uncertainty context. Accordingly, respondents needed to confirm that it was their first encounter with the pre-selected retailer. They were then instructed to visit the pre-selected retailer's website and freely explore its content. This open-ended exploration was intended to mimic a real-world purchasing experience and allow respondents to form opinions and intentions about the retailer. Such an approach has been shown to yield more accurate data (e.g., Shao et al., 2021; Wang et al., 2023).

In the second step, respondents were instructed to complete a questionnaire measuring the constructs used in Papers II and III (see operationalization in Table 4). Respondents completed the questionnaire based on their perceptions and experiences of visiting the retailer's website. To ensure contextual accuracy and high data quality, the questionnaire was translated into Swedish, minimizing language-related bias and enhancing reliability and validity. As a result, data were collected in Sweden in 2022, with a sample of 385 consumers. However, 21 respondents were excluded due to a lack of online purchasing experience, as individuals with limited online experience are not suitable for CBEC research and tend to be reluctant to make online purchases (Hazarika and Mousavi, 2021). As shown in Table 3, the final sample comprised 364 respondents, including 209 females and 155 males, with varying ages, online purchasing frequencies, and educational backgrounds.

Study 3 (3a, 3b, 3c)

Study 3 (Paper IV) consisted of three sub-studies (Study 3a, Study 3b, and Study 3c), each conducted via in-depth, semi-structured interviews with consumers in Sweden. Data for the three studies were collected over a five-month period in 2025, with participants across all three sub-studies recruited through a Swedish marketing research company. This approach has been shown to be effective in accessing relevant respondents and ensuring appropriate sample selection in CBEC research (Mou et al., 2020; Lee and Xiong, 2026). The company was informed about the study's aim, sampling criteria, and research context. Specifically, the study was presented as an academic investigation of consumer relationship development with POI-retailers in CBEC. They were instructed to recruit respondents with varying levels of purchasing experience with the retailer across the three sub-studies and to follow defined criteria when identifying POI-retailers. To ensure the reliability of the thesis, the

criteria for identifying a POI-retailer in Study 3 were the same as those used in Study 2.

In Study 3 (3a, 3b, 3c), three separate interview guides were developed, one for each study. For Study 3a, the interview guide focused on respondents' perceptions during their initial contact with a POI-retailer, capturing perceptions when encountering the retailer for the first time. Questions were asked about their initial impressions and perceptions, their evaluation of the retailer, and to provide reasons for their willingness or unwillingness to purchase from the retailer. Study 3a included 20 participants (respondents 1-20) with no prior experience with the POI-retailer and encountered it for the first time. In this study, three POI-retailers were pre-selected before data collection because the study focused on consumers' initial contact with the retailer. As discussed above, the three pre-selected retailers from France, the United States, and China were identified based on criteria derived from prior research (e.g., Safari and Yamin, 2016; Schu and Morschett, 2017). Participants were asked to freely select one retailer to explore in more detail and browse its website.

For Study 3a, the interview guide focused on participants' experiences of purchasing from a POI-retailer. Questions were asked about their experiences with the retailer, their purchases from it, and their reasons for repurchasing or avoiding it. Participants were asked to select a POI-retailer of their own choice and describe their experiences, including their interactions and purchases, as well as their reasons for continuing or discontinuing purchasing. This study involved 20 participants (respondents 21-40) who had made one to three purchases from a POI-retailer in CBEC. For Study 3c, the interview guide focused on respondents who had made several repeat purchases from a POI-retailer and had established a relationship with the retailer for at least one year. This duration ensured that the relationship was developed rather than based on occasional or short-term discrete transactions (Mukherjee and Nath, 2007). As such, this study explored why participants engaged in a relationship with the POI-retailer and, conversely, why they terminated the relationship. Questions were asked about their experiences with having a relationship with the retailer, what led them to continue or end the relationship, and how they evaluated it. Hence, this study explored both relationship continuation and termination to understand alternative relationship outcomes. This study involved 20 participants (respondents 41-60) who had made repeated purchases from the same POI-retailer and had a relationship with it.

Following previous studies (Styles and Hersch, 2005; Crick, 2021), data collection was terminated once saturation was achieved, which occurred at approximately 12 interviews. However, to ensure transparency, data collection continued with additional participants until each of the three studies included 20 participants, with no new patterns emerging. The interviews lasted an average of 43 minutes, were conducted face-to-face, audio-recorded with participants' consent, and transcribed verbatim for analysis. In both Study 3b and Study 3c, respondents were asked to identify a POI-retailer themselves,

thereby allowing them to draw on their own experiences with a specific retailer. In addition to the marketing company's role in recruiting participants with such experience, this was verified during data collection by following the criteria established in prior research for identifying POI-retailers (Daryanto et al., 2013; Safari and Yamin, 2016; Schu and Morschett, 2017). As shown in Table 3, a total of 60 in-depth interviews were conducted across three sub-studies (3a, 3b, and 3c), with 20 participants in each. The sample includes 31 females and 29 males, representing a range of ages, levels of online purchasing experience, and educational backgrounds.

Table 3. Sample Demographics for Study 2 and Study 3 (3a, 3b, 3c)

Demographics	Study 2	Study 3			
		Study 3a	Study 3b	Study 3c	Total
Number of participants (%)	364 (100%)	20 (33.3%)	20 (33.3%)	20 (33.3%)	60 (100%)
Gender					
Female	209 (57.4%)	11 (55%)	10 (50%)	10 (50%)	31 (51.7%)
Male	155 (42.6%)	9 (45%)	10 (50%)	10 (50%)	29 (48.3%)
Age					
18-29	270 (74.2%)	12 (60%)	10 (50%)	12 (60%)	34 (56.7%)
30-40	55 (15.1%)	8 (40%)	9 (45%)	8 (40%)	25 (41.7%)
41-50	20 (5.5%)	N/A	1 (5%)	N/A	1 (1.6%)
51-60	14 (3.8%)	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Over 61	5 (1.4)	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Education					
Doctorate degree	10 (2.7%)	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Master's degree	18 (4.9%)	3 (15%)	3 (15%)	3 (15%)	9 (15%)
Bachelor's degree	85 (23.4)	6 (30%)	7 (35%)	5 (25%)	18 (30%)
Vocational education	30 (8.2)	3 (15%)	1 (5%)	3 (15%)	7 (11.7%)
Upper secondary school	209 (57.4%)	8 (40%)	9 (45%)	9 (45%)	26 (43.3%)
Elementary school	12 (3.3%)	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Online purchase frequency					
Few times a day	3 (0.8%)	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Every day	3 (0.8%)	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Every week	33 9.1%)	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
3-4 times a month	89 (24.5%)	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
1-2 times a month	158 (43.4%)	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Few times a year	78 (21.4%)	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Regular purchaser	N/A	14 (70%)	16 (80%)	17 (85%)	47 (78.3%)
Occasional purchaser	N/A	6 (30%)	4 (20%)	3 (15%)	13 (21.7%)

Data Analysis, Measurements, and Research Quality Considerations

This thesis employed multiple data analysis techniques tailored to the specific design and objectives of each of the three studies. Accordingly, different analytical approaches were adopted to ensure methodological fit across the studies.

Study 1

In Study 1 (Paper I), both bibliometric and content analyses were used. For the bibliometric analysis, three techniques were adopted: bibliometric performance analysis, a conceptual thematic map, and bibliographic coupling (Zupic and Čater, 2015; Donthu et al., 2021). This study used VOSviewer 1.8.0 (van Eck and Waltman, 2010) and the Bibliometrix package 4.0.1 in RStudio (Aria and Cuccurullo, 2017), as each tool serves a distinct analytical purpose. Bibliometrix was used to conduct performance analyses and handle more complex bibliometric computations (Lim et al., 2024). VOSviewer was used to generate visualizations, as it offers a more user-friendly interface and stronger capabilities for mapping bibliographic coupling (Lim et al., 2024).

Bibliometric performance analysis was conducted to identify the main contributions (i.e., articles, journals, authors, institutions) in the research field (Donthu et al., 2021). Conceptual thematic map analysis was conducted to identify emerging themes in consumer behavior in CBEC (Zupic and Čater, 2015; Donthu et al., 2021). Specifically, this analysis maps the thematic structure of consumer behavior in CBEC by identifying "central/mainstream topics," "basic and transversal topics," "niche topics," and "emerging or weakly developed topics" along two axes of centrality and density into a cluster (Zupic and Čater, 2015; Aria and Cuccurullo, 2017). Following prior research (Zupic and Čater, 2015; Bretas and Alon, 2021), the Louvain algorithm was applied with a minimum cluster frequency of five to examine relationships among authors' keywords. The Louvain algorithm is a widely used and robust method for detecting clusters in large networks, as it groups nodes by maximizing modularity, thereby identifying clusters that are more strongly connected than would be expected by chance (Zupic and Čater, 2015; Wang and Koopman, 2017). In addition, bibliographic coupling analysis was conducted to identify current research streams within the field. This approach groups articles based on shared references, independent of citation counts, thereby revealing subfields within consumer behavior in CBEC (Zupic and Čater, 2015; Donthu et al., 2021). A minimum citation threshold of two was applied, resulting in 50 of the 81 articles being identified as the most interconnected.

This study further adopted content analysis, as it enables in-depth examination of prior research (Gaur and Kumar, 2018) and serves as a valuable complement for interpreting and enriching insights derived from bibliometric analyses (Paul and Criado, 2020). In this regard, an Excel spreadsheet was

used to manually examine 81 articles. In doing so, this thesis systematically reviewed all 81 paper's purpose/research question(s), method (i.e., data collection, sample, and retailer in focus), theoretical foundation, key variables (i.e., dependent, independent, mediating, moderating, and control variables), key findings, and contributions to gain a deeper understanding of the existing literature. Accordingly, the combined use of bibliometric and content analysis in Study 1 yielded a conceptual synthesis of the CBEC literature on consumer behavior and identified future research directions that served as the foundation for the subsequent papers in this thesis.

Study 2

In Study 2, IBM SPSS 29.0 and IBM AMOS 26.0 were used to analyze the quantitative data collected for Papers II and III. As shown in Table 4, the constructs were measured using previously validated scales (i.e., Dodds et al., 1991; Gefen et al., 2003; Bhattacherjee and Premkumar, 2004; Pavlou et al., 2007; Eastlick et al., 2006). Moreover, four control variables were included in the analysis: gender, age, education, and online purchase frequency, as suggested by previous research to control for purchase intention (Pavlou et al., 2007; Cui et al., 2020; Zerbini et al., 2022). The analyses for both papers followed a similar procedure. Specifically, the initial analyses entailed assessing normality using established thresholds from past research (Hair et al., 2010; Byrne, 2016), where skewness values within ±2 and kurtosis values within ±7 are considered acceptable. Results indicated that all variables met the specified thresholds, indicating that non-normality was not a major concern in Study 2.

The next steps entailed evaluating the validity and reliability of each measurement model. To begin, an exploratory factor analysis (EFA) was conducted to detect potential cross-loadings and to ensure that all items loaded onto their expected factors, using the principal extraction technique and the varimax method. After confirming that all loadings were aligned with their respective constructs, sampling adequacy was assessed using the Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin (KMO) test, with a recommended cut-off of 0.5 (Sallis et al., 2021). The KMO values for both papers were within the cut-off, indicating that the data were highly suitable for confirmatory factor analysis (CFA). Accordingly, CFA was conducted to assess the convergent validity of the constructs measured in the questionnaire. This involved evaluating factor loadings and average variance extracted (AVE), with acceptable thresholds of 0.6 for factor loadings (Tabachnick et al., 2013) and 0.6 for AVE (Fornell and Larcker, 1981). Discriminant validity was also examined by comparing the square roots of the AVEs with the inter-construct correlations (Fornell and Larcker, 1981). Next, the reliability of each construct was examined using Cronbach's alpha (α) and composite reliability (CR). This thesis followed the cut-offs of 0.7 for CR (Fornell and Larcker, 1981) and 0.8 for Cronbach's alpha (Cortina, 1993). Based on these analyses, the results

showed that the data collected in Study 2 for Papers II and III met all thresholds, thus confirming the presence of (discriminant and convergent) validity and (construct, item, and composite) reliability. In addition, the model fit for the measurement and structural models in both Papers II and III was assessed, and all indices (i.e., absolute, parsimony, and incremental indices) met the recommended thresholds (Ullman and Bentler, 2012).

For the structural models and hypothesis testing, this thesis used structural equation modeling in AMOS for both papers (Papers II and III). The findings of both papers revealed surprising results, including that some well-established hypotheses in the RET literature were not supported. For example, Paper II revealed that perceived ease of use and perceived usefulness had no significant effect on purchase intention, and that trust also had no significant effect on purchase intention. Similarly, Paper III showed that trust had no significant effect on either commitment or purchase intention. Therefore, an additional mediation analysis was conducted to better understand potential indirect effects among the constructs. Following Preacher and Hayes (2008), both papers (Papers II and III) used a bootstrapping technique in AMOS with 5,000 bootstrap samples to analyze the specific indirect effects.

Both papers checked for multicollinearity, common method variance (CMV), and robustness. Consistent with past studies (Dhir et al., 2024), multicollinearity was evaluated using variance inflation factors (VIFs) and Tolerance values. CMV was assessed using both ex-ante and post-hoc methods to reduce its influence. For the ex-ante method, the recommendations by MacKenzie and Podsakoff (2012) were followed. This involved considering the questionnaire's structure, voluntary participation, and encouraging respondents to read each unique question carefully. For the post-hoc test, several statistical methods were used to evaluate CMV, including the marker variable technique (Lindell and Whitney, 2001) and the Gaussian copula approach (Park and Gupta, 2012; Hult et al., 2018; Sarstedt et al., 2020). All tests indicated acceptable results, suggesting no concerns regarding multicollinearity, CMV, or model robustness in any of the papers from Study 2.

Table 4. Operationalization for Study 2

Construct	Item	Measurement	Reference
Purchase intention	PI1	The likelihood of buying from the company* is very high	Dodds et al. (1991)
	PI2	If I were going to buy textile, I would consider buying it from the company	
	PI3	I would consider buying from the company	
	PI4	The probability that I would consider buying from the company is high	
	PI5	I would consider buying from the company	
Trust	TR1	I believe the company understands the market they work in	Pavlou et al. (2007)
	TR2	I believe the company knows a lot about its products	
	TR3	I believe the company is likely to be reliable	
	TR4	I believe the company is honest	
	TR5	I think the company will keep the promises they make	
	TR6	I think the company has good intentions toward me	
	TR7	I think the company is well meaning	
Commitment	CO1	I am willing to put effort into helping the company to be successful	Eastlick et al. (2006)
	CO2	I would recommend the company to my friends/family	
	CO3	I would be proud to be a customer at the company	
	CO4	I would be happy to choose the company over other companies	
	CO5	I care about the fate of the company	
	CO6	I think the company would be among the best to shop from	
Attitude	AT1	Purchasing from the company is a good idea	Bhattacherjee and
	AT2	Purchasing from the company is a wise move	Premkumar (2004)
	AT3	Purchasing from the company is a positive step	
	AT4	Purchasing from the company is an effective idea	
	AT5	I have an extremely positive attitude toward the company	
Uncertainty	UN1	I feel that buying from the company involves a high degree of uncertainty	Pavlou et al. (2007)
	UN2	I feel the uncertainty associated with buying from the company is high	
	UN3	I feel exposed to many transaction uncertainties if I buy from the company	

	UN4	I think there is a high degree of product uncertainty when buying from the company(i.e., the product I receive may not be exactly what I want)	
Perceived ease of use	PEOU1	The company's website is easy to use	Gefen et al. (2003)
	PEOU2	It is easy to become skillful at using the company's website	
	PEOU3	Learning to operate on the company's website is easy	
	PEOU4	The company's website is flexible to interact with	
	PEOU5	My interaction with the company's website is clear and understandable	
	PEOU6	It is easy to interact with the company's website	
Perceived usefulness	PU1	The company's website is useful for searching and buying fabrics	Gefen et al. (2003)
	PU2	The company's website improves my performance in fabric searching and buying	
	PU3	The company's website enables me to search and buy fabrics faster	
	PU4	The company's website enhances my effectiveness in fabric searching and buying	
	PU5	The company's website makes it easier to search for and purchase fabrics	
	PU6	The company's website increases my productivity in searching and purchasing fabrics	

Notes: *The label “the company” was used to refer to the pre-selected POI-retailer in Study 2

Study 3 (3a, 3b, 3c)

To analyze the data for Study 3, this thesis combined Spiggle's (1994) framework for interpreting qualitative data in consumer research with the Gioia methodology (Gioia et al., 2013; Magnani and Gioia, 2023). While Spiggle (1994) provides an interpretive foundation for developing theoretical insights from empirical observations in consumer research. The Gioia methodology offers a transparent and systematic structure for organizing and presenting the analysis through first-order codes, second-order themes, and aggregate dimensions (Gioia et al., 2013; Magnani and Gioia, 2023). The combination of these two approaches enabled a systematic and transparent analytical procedure. It is important to clarify that although the Gioia methodology was originally developed for inductive research (Gioia et al., 2013), more recent work suggests that it is also well suited for abductive approaches, as it enables systematic engagement between data and theory (Magnani and Gioia, 2023). This notion is also supported in previous marketing research (e.g., see Ramos et al., 2024; Crick and Crick, 2025; Roohanifar et al., 2025). As such, the Gioia methodology was most suitable for this thesis, as it facilitates a structured comparison between empirical data and theory and captures variation in meaning across the three studies. This, in turn, ensures greater analytical rigor through systematic data coding and analysis (Gioia et al., 2013; Magnani and Gioia, 2023).

Accordingly, the analysis began with a careful reading of the data from each study. The three studies were initially analyzed separately, and first-order codes were developed from interview quotations for each study. These were subsequently grouped into second-order themes and aggregate dimensions. Throughout this process, the analysis moved iteratively between data and theory, drawing on existing RET literature to interpret emerging patterns. While remaining open to new and unexpected categories (Miles and Huberman, 1984), this thesis particularly drew on concepts of uncertainty, trust, commitment, purchasing, repurchasing, avoidance, and relationships, all of which were derived from the RET literature (e.g., Eastlick et al., 2006; Pavlou et al., 2007; Cui et al., 2020).

After analyzing the studies separately, this thesis employed the constant comparative method (Glaser, 1965; Glaser and Strauss, 1967) to compare data both within and across the three studies. This enabled the identification of similarities and differences in emerging patterns and the refinement of categories across datasets. Through this comparison, it was observed that while the same aggregate dimensions were present across all studies, their expressions differed between them. For example, trust took a different form for respondents in Study 3a than in Study 3c, shifting from information-based to affective trust. The form of commitment also varied across the three studies. In Study 3a, it was reflected in consumers' investment of time and effort in information search, whereas in Study 3c, it shifted toward retention. In other

words, the analysis showed that the same core concepts took on distinct expressions across the studies, reflecting systematic variation rather than inconsistency. This indicated that the aggregate dimensions were not static but evolved in their form as the consumer relationship developed.

Based on the Gioia methodology applied across the three sub-studies, the second-order themes of *retailer uncertainty*, *product uncertainty*, *website uncertainty*, *psychic distance,* and *relationship uncertainty* were grouped under the aggregate dimension of *uncertainty*. The second-order themes of *initial trust based on information cues*, *experience-based trust*, and *affective trust* were grouped under the aggregate dimension of *trust*, while *internal and external search commitments*, *recommendations*, and *long-term retention* formed the aggregate dimension of *commitment*. These findings (Paper IV) indicate that uncertainty, trust, and commitment take different forms across the three studies, as reflected in the variation among the second-order themes.

4. Papers

This thesis is based on four papers that examine consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts. It uses cross-border e-commerce (CBEC), specifically POI-retailers in CBEC, as an empirical setting characterized by high uncertainty. Therefore, in this fourth chapter, it is important to clarify that these terms are used interchangeably, as POI-retailers in CBEC are conceptualized as a high-uncertainty context.

Accordingly, Paper I provides a systematic literature review of consumer behavior in CBEC, identifying six types of uncertainty: website, product, retailer, purchasing, post-purchasing, and relationship uncertainty. The paper also highlights that research on consumer purchasing toward POI-retailers in CBEC remains limited. Papers II and III build on this foundation and focus on website uncertainty and product and retailer uncertainty, respectively. Specifically, Paper II integrates two influential theories to examine the effects of website uncertainty on trust and commitment, and their subsequent impact on purchase intention during the initial phase of consumer relationship development. Paper III extends this approach by developing a relational view to study the effects of retailer- and product-related uncertainty on trust and commitment, and their subsequent impact on purchase intention during the initial phase of consumer relationship development. Findings from Papers II and III reveal unexpected results, indicating that the initial phase in high-uncertainty contexts differs from patterns observed in previous RET studies. To provide deeper insight, Paper IV examines consumer relationship development in depth, from the consumer's first encounter with a retailer to the point at which a relationship is established. Specifically, it demonstrates how different types of uncertainty differentially shape trust and commitment across three phases of consumer relationship development: initial, building, and relationship.

Table 5 provides an overview of the four papers and illustrates how this thesis examines consumer relationship development and the different types of uncertainty that affect it. The table also presents the three phases of consumer relationship development: initial, building, and relationship. These phases were identified during the research process of this thesis (Paper IV) and are included in Table 5 to clarify which phase each paper addresses.

Paper I: A Literature Review of Consumer Behavior in Cross-Border E-commerce: A Conceptual Framework

The aim of Paper I is to provide an overview of the current state of knowledge regarding consumer behavior in CBEC and to develop a conceptual framework to guide future research. Hence, the paper conducts a systematic literature review following the PRISMA protocol (Page et al., 2021). As such, 81 peer-reviewed articles published between 2005 and 2024 were identified from the Web of Science and Scopus databases. To analyze these articles, the paper uses a mixed-methods approach, combining quantitative bibliometric and qualitative content analysis techniques.

Based on the findings from these analyses, this paper identifies six research streams that capture how previous studies have examined consumer behavior in CBEC. Accordingly, it synthesizes these studies at a higher level of abstraction by centering on the concept of uncertainty. Specifically, prior studies that focused on product-related factors in CBEC (e.g., product description, product presentation) were conceptualized as product uncertainty. Similarly, studies that focused on website-related factors (e.g., perceived ease of use, usefulness, design, cultural adaptation, privacy, security) were conceptualized as website uncertainty. Studies addressing retailer-related factors (e.g., reputation, familiarity) were thus conceptualized as retailer uncertainty. The same logic was applied to the remaining research streams. As a result, this paper identifies six types of uncertainty that consumers encounter in CBEC: (1) website uncertainty, (2) product uncertainty, (3) retailer uncertainty, (4) purchasing uncertainty, (5) post-purchasing uncertainty, and (6) relationship uncertainty. The rationale for using the concept of uncertainty was twofold: first, prior studies consistently show that consumers experience uncertainty in CBEC (Huang and Chang, 2019; Cui et al., 2020; Mou et al., 2020b). Second, uncertainty is a core concept in RET, which forms the theoretical foundation for this thesis.

Accordingly, to structure these uncertainties in CBEC, this paper draws on Paul and Criado's (2020) framework-based review, specifically the ADO (antecedents, decision, outcomes) framework. This framework enables the systematic structuring and synthesis of prior research, organizing studies into coherent categories to clarify the relationships between key factors and reveal a more robust structure (Paul and Criado, 2020). However, because consumer CBEC purchasing often involves a distinct evaluative phase under uncertainty, referred to as deliberation (Safari and Yamin, 2016), and the analysis revealed that prior CBEC research has primarily focused on post-purchase factors, the original ADO framework is limited in its ability to capture the realities of CBEC. Hence, to more accurately reflect the CBEC research landscape, this paper introduces *Deliberation* as an additional phase, resulting in the ADDO (antecedents, decision, deliberation, outcomes) framework. Deliberation was positioned between decision and outcomes, as consumers often

engage in post-purchase evaluation before longer-term outcomes such as consumer relationships emerge (Safari and Yamin, 2016).

Accordingly, the six identified uncertainties were organized across the ADDO phases to conceptualize the different types of uncertainty that arise and influence consumer behavior throughout the CBEC journey. To determine in which phase, for example, product uncertainty, should be positioned within the ADDO framework, the studies representing that concept were closely examined. Specifically, their research methods were analyzed, focusing on the types of respondents used and whether they had prior purchase experience (e.g., first-time purchases, repeat purchases, or an established relationship with the retailer). In doing so, each type of uncertainty was systematically positioned within the ADDO framework. As a result, this process led to the development of a conceptual framework for consumer behavior in CBEC that captures what types of uncertainty unfold and when.

Importantly, the findings of Paper I also indicate that these uncertainties are shaped by the type of retailer from which consumers purchase. Specifically, consumers can purchase from three types of retailers in CBEC: (1) active online internationalization (AOI) retailers, (2) default online internationalization (DOI) retailers, and (3) partial online internationalization (POI) retailers. As these retailer types differ in familiarity and resource availability, they vary in their ability to reduce uncertainty. Larger and more established retailers mitigate uncertainty more effectively, while less well-known retailers face greater difficulties in doing so. Notably, most research has focused on the former retailer types, with limited research on consumer purchasing from POI-retailers.

This paper has three main contributions. First, prior research in CBEC has offered limited guidance in providing a conceptual framework for understanding consumer behavior. This paper addresses that gap by proposing a conceptual framework that synthesizes prior research. Second, the CBEC literature is largely characterized by a short-term, transactional view of consumer behavior, with limited attention to long-term behaviors beyond the initial purchase, such as relationship development. This paper addresses this limitation by developing a long-term framework that captures ongoing evaluation and post-purchase processes. It does so by extending the ADO framework into ADDO through the introduction of a deliberation phase, thereby more accurately capturing consumer evaluation under uncertainty in CBEC. Finally, this paper identifies six types of uncertainty that shape the consumer CBEC journey and organizes them within the ADDO framework to illustrate where they are most salient across the journey. In doing so, it advances understanding of what uncertainties arise at different phases of the consumer CBEC journey.

Paper II: Consumer Purchase Intention toward POI-retailers in Cross-Border E-commerce: An Integration of Technology Acceptance Model and Commitment-Trust Theory

Building on the findings from Paper I, which indicate that research on consumer purchasing from POI-retailers is limited, that consumers face multiple uncertainties, and that a relational perspective is underexplored. Thus, Paper II was developed to examine consumer purchase intention toward POI-retailers (i.e., a high-uncertainty context in this thesis) in order to understand the initial phase of consumer relationship development. To address this, Paper II draws on two influential theories explaining consumer purchase intention, namely the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) and the Commitment-Trust Theory (CTT), a sub-theory of RET. These theories have largely been adopted in isolation to study purchase intention and rarely integrated.

Therefore, the purpose of Paper II is to integrate TAM and CTT to explain consumer purchase intention toward POI retailers in CBEC. This integration is necessary to provide a more comprehensive account of purchase intention in the initial phase of relationship development by capturing both website-related uncertainty and relational mechanisms. Specifically, TAM captures website-related uncertainty through perceived ease of use and perceived usefulness, which have been widely applied to explain consumer perceptions of websites (Gefen et al., 2003; Cho and Sagynov, 2015; Chen and Yang, 2021; Zerbini et al., 2022; Taufique et al., 2024). In this paper, these concepts are used to reflect website uncertainty, as Paper I identified this type of uncertainty as particularly salient in shaping the initial phase. In parallel, CTT contributes the relational mechanisms of trust and commitment, drawing on prior B2C research (Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Wang et al., 2016; Cui et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2023).

Based on 364 respondents who visited a real-life POI-retailer's country-specific website and completed a questionnaire, the findings reveal that perceived usefulness, perceived ease of use, and trust do not directly affect purchase intention in a high-uncertainty context. Instead, perceived usefulness and perceived ease of use influence purchase intention only indirectly through trust and commitment, while trust itself must be mediated by commitment to affect purchase intention. In high-uncertainty contexts, commitment appears to play a more substantial role in influencing purchase intention than trust. In other words, the paper demonstrates that the path to consumer purchase intention in high-uncertainty contexts differs from the patterns identified in prior research.

This paper has several contributions. First, it contributes to the literature on consumer purchase intention in CBEC by developing and testing an integrated model that combines TAM and CTT. Prior research has typically applied these

frameworks separately or only partially integrated them. This study advances the literature by fully integrating TAM and CTT and empirically testing the proposed model. Second, it demonstrates that TAM is only partially effective in explaining consumer purchase intention toward POI-retailers. While perceived ease of use influences perceived usefulness, their direct effects on purchase intention are not supported. Instead, they influence purchase intention indirectly through trust and commitment, suggesting a different role in high-uncertainty contexts. Finally, the findings provide partial support for CTT. Commitment emerges as the only direct driver of purchase intention, indicating that consumers must first develop commitment before forming purchase intentions. In contrast, trust does not directly influence purchase intention, suggesting that it may take longer to develop in contexts where consumers are unfamiliar with the retailer. Based on the above, this paper indicates that the path to consumer purchase intention toward POI-retailers differs from the findings of previous studies based on TAM and CTT. In other words, the initial phase of consumer relationship development unfolds differently in high-uncertainty contexts.

Paper III: Exploring Consumer Purchase Intention in Cross-Border E-commerce: A Relational View

Building on the unexpected finding in Paper II that trust did not affect purchase intention, Paper III continues to examine consumer purchase intention during the initial phase of consumer relationship development. Accordingly, the aim of this paper is to explore purchase intention toward POI-retailers in CBEC from a relational view. This paper draws on the core RET concepts of uncertainty, trust, and commitment, and also integrates insights from the consumer attitude literature. Consumer attitudes can shape positive perceptions and enhance purchase intentions (Patel et al., 2023; Pop et al., 2023). Hence, this paper argues that attitude may strengthen relational antecedents and foster purchase intention despite perceived uncertainty. This paper specifically focuses on the effects of uncertainty related to the retailer and the product, as Paper I revealed that these types of uncertainty are particularly salient in shaping the initial phase of consumer relationship development.

This paper relies on data collected from 364 respondents who visited a real-life POI-retailer's country-specific website and completed a questionnaire. The findings indicate that uncertainty (product and retailer) negatively affects consumer trust but has no significant effect on consumer attitude toward the retailer. This suggests that although heightened uncertainty may undermine consumers' trust in the retailer, it does not necessarily translate into less favorable attitudes. Moreover, purchase intention toward POI-retailers is primarily driven by consumer attitude and commitment, whereas trust does not exhibit

a significant direct effect on either commitment or purchase intention. Instead, trust appears to play a more indirect role through the mediating effect of attitude on commitment and purchase intention during the initial phase of consumer relationship development. Accordingly, attitude serves as a key pathway through which trust influences both commitment and purchase intention. In other words, consumers' positive attitudes can, at least in part, compensate for the limited role of trust in driving these outcomes, particularly when trust is constrained by the negative impact of uncertainty.

This paper has several contributions. First, it increases the understanding of how consumer purchase intention can develop despite uncertainty, thereby creating the prerequisites for relationship development. By integrating RET and consumer attitude into a unified framework, an approach largely overlooked in prior research, this paper develops a relational view for studying consumer purchase intention. Second, it challenges the conventional understanding of trust in the initial phase of a consumer relationship development. In contrast to RET research showing the significant effect of trust on commitment and purchase intention, this paper indicates that trust plays a different role under high uncertainty. Third, the proposed framework provides new insights into how retailers, particularly unfamiliar POI-retailers, can establish the prerequisites necessary for relationship development despite consumer uncertainty. While prior research shows that uncertainty arising from retailer unfamiliarity hampers trust and, in turn, relationship building (Darke et al., 2016; Sharma and Klein, 2025), this study identifies how such relationships can still begin to form under these conditions, albeit differently from what RET suggests.

Paper IV: Consumer Relationship Development in Cross-Border E-commerce

Since Papers II and III indicate that trust does not influence purchase intention or commitment during the initial phase, Paper IV was developed to examine consumer relationship development in greater depth. Therefore, the aim of this paper was to study consumer relationship development with POI-retailers in CBEC and propose a framework for a better understanding of this development. This paper relies on three sub-studies (Study 3a, 3b, 3c), each targeting respondents at different phases of relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts. A total of 60 in-depth interviews (20 per sub-study) were conducted. The paper employs an abductive approach to analyze the data and develop a conceptual framework.

The findings of this paper show that consumer relationship development in CBEC unfolds across three phases: initial, building, and relationship, each characterized by distinct roles of uncertainty, trust, and commitment. In the

initial phase, consumers face multiple types of uncertainty related to the retailer, the product, the website, and psychic distance to the retailer's home country. Trust is information-based and develops through the evaluation of information cues, while commitment takes the form of search activities in which consumers invest time and effort to reduce uncertainty. Moreover, in the initial phase, findings show that commitment precedes trust, yet it both influences consumer purchase intention.

It is important to highlight that, in contrast to Papers II and III, which followed prior RET-based research yet found that trust does not affect commitment and purchase intention, Paper IV offers a possible explanation for this result. Specifically, the findings suggest that consumers must engage in information search to reduce uncertainty before forming trust and purchase intentions, implying that commitment precedes and enables trust. Under such conditions, this paper suggests that trust may influence purchase intention only after the initial commitment has been established, indicating that the direction of trust and commitment may differ. This helps explain why trust did not affect purchase intention in earlier models that assumed trust precedes commitment. In Papers II and III, it was argued, based on prior RET studies, that consumers must first establish trust before increasing commitment. However, this paper indicates that in high-uncertainty contexts, consumers must first commit time and effort to information search before trust can form and influence purchase intention.

Furthermore, the paper reveals that during the building phase, trust becomes experience-based as consumers rely on their own purchase experiences, which reduces uncertainty, while commitment evolves from search activities to include consumers' recommendations. In contrast to the previous phase, trust precedes commitment in the building phase, with both driving consumer repurchasing. In the relationship phase, trust and commitment continue to strengthen and mutually reinforce each other. Despite this, uncertainty does not disappear but persists, particularly in the form of relationship uncertainty, as well as remaining retailer and product uncertainty. This suggests that even in well-established relationships, consumers must continue to manage ongoing uncertainty. The reciprocal interplay between trust and commitment enables them to do so, thereby sustaining the relationship.

This paper makes several contributions. First, it develops a three-phase conceptual framework for understanding consumer relationship development, showing that uncertainty, trust, and commitment, as well as their interplay, exert distinct effects across the phases. In particular, the findings demonstrate that the direction of the trust-commitment relationship varies across phases, diverging from established RET research, suggesting that trust precedes commitment (Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Gruen, 1995; Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Wang et al., 2016; Lin et al., 2023). Second, this paper shows that uncertainty, trust, and commitment take different forms and vary across the phases. Trust, for example, evolves from being largely information-

based in the initial phase to becoming more experience-based and affective in the later phases. Similarly, commitment transitions from information search activities to a more enduring motivation to recommend the retailer and maintain the relationship despite ongoing uncertainty. Accordingly, this paper provides important insights into how RET's core relational mechanisms operate in high-uncertainty contexts.

Table 5. Summary of the Papers

Paper	Aim	Concepts	(Types of uncertainty)	Method	Findings	Contribution	Phases in Consumer Relationship Development*		
							Initial	Building	Relationship
I	To provide an overview of the current state of knowledge regarding consumer behavior in CBEC and propose a conceptual framework to guide future research.	Uncertainty	(Website-, Product-, Retailer-, Purchasing-, Post-purchasing-, and Relationship uncertainty)	Mixed-method; quantitative bibliometric analysis, and qualitative content analysis of 81 peer-reviewed articles	The findings show that consumers encounter six types of uncertainty throughout their purchasing journey in CBEC. The findings indicate that the CBEC literature is largely characterized by a short-term, transactional view of consumer behavior, with limited attention to a relational perspective. The results also demonstrate that research in high-uncertainty contexts remains scarce.	This paper synthesizes the consumer CBEC literature and proposes a conceptual framework for consumer behavior in CBEC.	X	X	X
II	To integrate the technology acceptance model and commitment-trust theory to shed light on consumer purchase intentions toward POI-retailers in CBEC.	Website perceived ease of use, Perceived usefulness, Trust, Commitment, Purchase intention	(Website uncertainty)	Quantitative, 364 questionnaires	The findings reveal that perceived ease of use, perceived usefulness (i.e., website uncertainty), and trust do not directly affect purchase intention. Instead, perceived usefulness and ease of use need to be mediated by both trust and commitment, while trust needs to be mediated by commitment to affect purchase intention. Unlike trust, commitment is the primary driver of purchase intentions.	This paper integrates the technology acceptance model and commitment-trust theory to study consumer purchase intention during the initial phase of consumer relationship development.	X		
III	To explore consumer purchase intentions toward POI-retailers in CBEC from a relational view.	Uncertainty, Attitude, Trust, Commitment, Purchase intention	(Product- and Retailer uncertainty)	Quantitative, 364 questionnaires	The results show that uncertainty (product and retailer) negatively affects trust but not attitude. Trust does not affect commitment and purchase intention. Instead, purchase intention is affected by attitude and commitment. Moreover, trust is mediated by attitude and commitment, which, in turn, affect consumers' purchase intentions.	This paper develops a relational view to study consumer purchase intention during the initial phase of consumer relationship development.	X		
IV	To study consumer relationship development with POI-retailers in CBEC and propose a framework to better understand this.	Uncertainty, Trust, Commitment, (Re)purchase intention, Actual (re)purchasing, Relationship	(Website-, Product-, Retailer-, and Relationship uncertainty)	Qualitative, three sub-studies, 60 in-depth (20 per sub-study) interviews	The findings reveal that the relational mechanisms of uncertainty, trust, and commitment, as well as their interplay, vary across the phases of consumer relationship development. Moreover, these mechanisms take a different form as the relationship develops.	This paper develops a three-phase conceptual framework for understanding consumer relationship development. This framework shows the dynamic interplay between uncertainty, trust, and commitment.	X	X	X

Notes: *The phase labels and the number of phases presented are developed within this thesis, drawing on previous RET research (e.g., Ford, 1980; Dwyer et al., 1987; Fournier, 1998; Wang et al., 2000; Batonda and Perry, 2003; Campbell et al., 2009; Campbell, 2019).

5. Discussion

Toward a Conceptual Framework of Consumer Relationship Development in High-Uncertainty Contexts

This thesis has studied consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts. Specifically, it investigated what types of uncertainty affect this development and how consumers nonetheless develop relationships in high-uncertainty contexts. This thesis used a POI-retailer in CBEC as a research context and thus an empirical example of a high-uncertainty context in which consumers can develop relationships. Therefore, it is important to clarify that this thesis contextualizes the uncertainties encountered in this specific context. Other forms of uncertainty may arise in different contexts; however, they fall outside the scope of this thesis, as those contexts are of a different nature than those characterizing high-uncertainty contexts.

Within the RET literature, several conceptual models of relationship development have been proposed (e.g., Ford, 1980; Dwyer et al., 1987; Larson, 1992; Evans and Laskin, 1994; Wilson, 1995; Batonda and Perry, 2003). However, the majority are grounded in B2B markets, with only a few extending to B2C markets (e.g., Fournier, 1998; Wang et al., 2000; Campbell et al., 2009; Campbell, 2019). While these models differ in their focus and context, they share a common characteristic: most were developed in low-uncertainty contexts. As a result, conceptual models for consumer relationship development have not only been limited overall but have also been particularly absent in high-uncertainty contexts. To increase theoretical understanding of this underexplored area, this thesis draws on insights from the four papers (Papers I-IV) to develop a conceptual framework for consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts. The theoretical foundation of this framework is RET, specifically grounded in the concepts of uncertainty, trust, and commitment.

Figure 1 presents the conceptual model of consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts. Drawing on previous RET-based studies (e.g., Ford, 1980; Dwyer et al., 1987; Fournier, 1998; Wang et al., 2000; Batonda and Perry, 2003; Campbell et al., 2009; Campbell, 2019), the model builds on the idea that consumer relationships develop across different phases. While these studies differ in their labels and number of phases, they generally

converge on a common logic: relationship development progresses from an initial encounter[6] to a buildup period[7] and, ultimately, to a developed relationship[8]. Building on this insight, Figure 1 presents a three-phase conceptual model of consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts, labeled the *initial*, *building*, and *relationship phases*. The initial phase refers to consumers' first encounter with the retailer, without any prior familiarity or experience. The building phase refers to the period in which consumers accumulate experience with the retailer through interactions and repeated purchases. The relationship phase refers to the point at which the consumer's relationship with the retailer is fully developed in a high-uncertainty context. It is important to clarify that the conceptual model (Figure 1) is based on situations in which consumer relationship development occurs. At the same time, this thesis acknowledges that not all consumers develop relationships in high-uncertainty contexts, and even when relationships are formed, they may eventually end. However, this thesis does not focus on explaining such avoidance or dissolution. Instead, given the limited research on consumer relationships in high-uncertainty contexts, it focuses on the phases through which relationships emerge and develop.

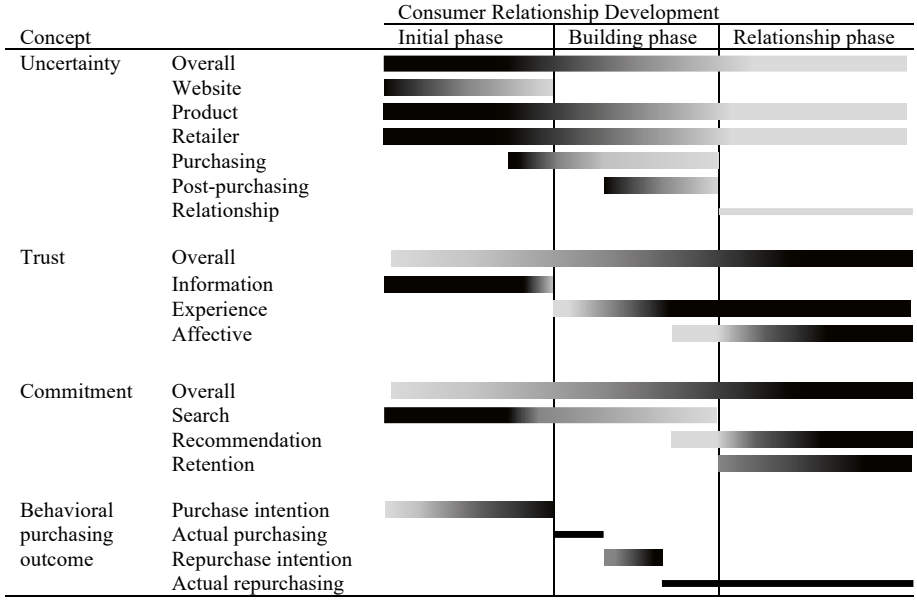
During the progression of these three phases, consumers accumulate experience as they make gradual investments, such as time, effort, and repeated actual purchases, which support the establishment of trust and commitment and the reduction of uncertainty. Accordingly, Figure 1 shows that uncertainty, trust, and commitment take distinct forms across the three phases, which together shape consumers' behavioral purchasing outcomes during the relationship development. In the initial phase, uncertainty centers on the website, product, retailer, and an initial glimpse of purchasing uncertainty. Trust is information-based, formed through consumers' evaluation of available cues, while commitment manifests as search activities requiring consumers' time and effort. The behavioral purchasing outcome in this phase is purchase intention, reflecting consumers' willingness to buy.

In the building phase, while website uncertainty is largely resolved, uncertainty continues to center around the product, retailer, and purchasing. As consumers gain experience through actual purchases, post-purchasing uncertainty also emerges as they assess actual outcomes. Trust becomes experienced-based, and commitment continues through search activities while extending to recommendation behaviors. Behavioral purchasing outcomes in this phase include actual purchase, repurchase intention, and repurchasing. It is

[6] This is labeled as initiation (Fournier, 1998), attraction (Campbell et al., 2009), investigation (Wang et al., 2000), awareness (Dwyer et al., 1987), pre-relationship (Ford, 1980), or relationship starting (Batonda and Perry, 2003).
[7] This is labeled as growth (Fournier, 1998), build-up (Campbell et al., 2009), exploration (Dwyer et al., 1987), or development stage (Ford, 1980; Batonda and Perry, 2003).
[8] This is labeled as maintenance (Fournier, 1998), continuance (Campbell, 2019), or expansion (Dwyer et al., 1987).

important to clarify that although the visual representation in Figure 1 shows behavioral purchasing outcomes as sequential in the building phase, these outcomes occur in a cyclical manner: consumers purchase, form repurchase intentions, engage in actual repurchasing, and generate new repurchase intentions. Between these purchases, consumers engage in deliberation by evaluating their experiences, which in turn shape their uncertainty, trust, and commitment. In the relationship phase, uncertainty concerns the product, the retailer, and the relationship itself. Trust deepens into both experience-based and affective forms, while commitment is expressed through recommendations and retention. The main behavioral outcome is consumers' actual repurchasing.

Figure 1. Consumer Relationship Development in High-Uncertainty Contexts



The visual logic of the conceptual model (Figure 1), particularly the use of horizontal bars to illustrate the presence and continuity of concepts across phases, is inspired by Wilson's (1995) model of buyer-seller relationships. Accordingly, the horizontal length of each bar in Figure 1 indicates the phase(s) in which a given concept and its typology are present, as well as when it becomes less salient. Bars that extend across multiple phases indicate concepts with continued presence, whereas shorter bars indicate phase-specific presence and, thus, shorter periods. In addition, the shading of each bar indicates the strength of the concept, with darker shading representing greater strength and lighter shading representing weaker strength. In other words, the length and shading of the bars together represent the magnitude of a concept, capturing both the extent to which it is present (indicated by bar length) and the

strength with which it is experienced (indicated by bar shading). In the following sections, this thesis explains how consumer relationships develop, identifies the types of uncertainty that affect this development, and discusses how these insights relate to or differ from previous RET-based studies.

The Initial Phase

The initial phase marks the beginning of consumer relationship development in a high-uncertainty context. It refers to consumers' first encounter with a small, resource-constrained retailer, without any prior familiarity or experience. This phase begins when consumers enter the retailer's website and engage with the retailer for the first time under conditions of high uncertainty. It is important to clarify that, prior to entering the initial phase, consumers have typically already recognized an interest in a product, which motivates them to consider a retailer from which to make a purchase. In many cases, consumers enter a high-uncertainty context because the product cannot be obtained elsewhere (Paper IV). Accordingly, consumers enter the initial phase without familiarity or prior experience with the retailer, website, and product, resulting in high overall uncertainty. The primary objective of this phase is thus to reduce uncertainty. By doing so, consumers can form purchase intentions and increase the likelihood of transitioning to the subsequent phase and continuing the development of the relationship.

Findings in this thesis show that developing purchase intentions during this phase is far from straightforward (Papers II and III). The initial phase is the most challenging and fragile part of relationship development, as consumers' trust and commitment are at their lowest while uncertainty is at its highest. Taking a closer look at Figure 1, uncertainty in the initial phase originates from three main sources: retailer uncertainty (related to unfamiliarity); product uncertainty (related to quality); and website uncertainty (related to perceived ease of use and usefulness) (Papers II and III). Collectively, these sources of uncertainty shape early trust and commitment and determine whether relationship development can proceed. In addition, as the phase unfolds, a fourth type of uncertainty, purchasing uncertainty (related to execution of purchase), gradually emerges as consumers begin to form purchase intentions, which serve as the behavioral outcome of this phase (Paper I).

As this initial phase begins, with consumers encountering a retailer in a high-uncertainty context, they face two possible paths. They may either engage in avoidance behavior, thereby terminating relationship development at the outset, or they may continue the initial phase by actively seeking to reduce uncertainty and build trust. If consumers choose the first option, the initial phase ends immediately. If they choose the second, the initial phase continues. For consumers who continue, commitment in the initial phase primarily takes the form of information-related activities. Prior studies have suggested that

consumers engage in information search to reduce uncertainty (Urbany et al., 1989; Safari and Yamin, 2016), and this thesis (Paper IV) similarly shows that consumers invest time and effort in searching for information to reduce uncertainty and establish a basis for trust. Here, findings indicate that consumers actively search for information both internally (e.g., third-party endorsements, certifications, delivery company collaborations, payment methods, product images) and externally (e.g., online reviews, social media, asking friends and family) (Paper IV). Thus, the term "Search" in Figure 1 reflects consumers' search activities related to the specific potential relationship with the retailer they encounter, rather than a general, non-specific information search. In this sense, consumers' search activity represents an early form of commitment in the initial phase of relationship development.

In this phase, Paper IV shows that trust is information-based and emerges from consumers' commitment to information search, including online reviews, website information, product images, and third-party endorsements. Importantly, trust does not arise simply from exposure to these cues; instead, it develops through consumers' active search and careful evaluation of their reliability. When these search activities are perceived as overly time-consuming or cognitively demanding, consumers are unlikely to invest further, thereby constraining trust formation and weakening purchase intention. Conversely, when consumers engage in information search, the outcome of this commitment determines whether trust and uncertainty increase or decrease. Positive information reduces uncertainty and supports trust formation, whereas negative information increases uncertainty and undermines trust. In the latter case, the initial phase ends without the formation of purchase intention.

These findings from Paper IV, and the mechanisms they reveal, help explain the role of trust observed in Papers II and III. Specifically, they clarify that the influence of trust is directly shaped by the different types of uncertainty present. When website uncertainty is salient (Paper II), trust does not directly affect purchase intention but operates indirectly through commitment. Trust influences commitment, which emerges as the sole direct driver of purchase intention. By contrast, when retailer and product uncertainty dominate (Paper III), trust affects neither commitment nor purchase intention. Under such conditions, the initial phase deviates from established RET ideas, in which trust typically precedes both commitment and purchase intention (Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Wang et al., 2016; Cui et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2023). Because consumers lack familiarity- and experience-based cues to support early trust formation, commitment is instead driven by information search rather than trust, thereby altering the conventional trust-commitment ordering (Paper IV). This finding is important because it demonstrates that the foundational RET suggestion (that trust is the primary driver of relational and behavioral outcomes) does not universally hold under conditions of heightened uncertainty. Instead, it reveals that the role of trust is contingent on both the dominant type of uncertainty and the phase of relationship

development. Consequently, regardless of the dominant type of uncertainty, commitment remains the primary driver and serves as a more immediate mechanism for shaping purchase intention in the initial phase of relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts.

Based on the above, the initial phase of relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts departs from prior RET-based studies, which consistently show that trust precedes commitment in the initial phase (Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Wang et al., 2016; Cui et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2023). Under conditions of heightened uncertainty, this ordering is reversed (Paper IV). Consumers are not exposed to information cues such as familiarity or prior experience that could support their trust-building. Instead, they must actively search for information cues themselves, committing time and effort to information-seeking activities, through which information-based trust is subsequently formed. Moreover, in high-uncertainty contexts, the negative effect of uncertainty reduces the likelihood that consumers will develop purchase intentions (Paper III). This phase also deviates from prior research, which shows that a website's perceived ease of use and usefulness have a direct and significant effect on purchase intention (Singh et al., 2006; Cho and Sagynov, 2015; Chen and Yang, 2021; Zerbini et al., 2022; Taufique et al., 2024). In high-uncertainty contexts, however, this pattern differs. Rather than directly influencing purchase intention, perceived ease of use and usefulness primarily influence trust and commitment (Paper II). These departures highlight that, in high-uncertainty contexts, the initial phase is shaped by information search commitments, which serve as the primary mechanism for reducing uncertainty and fostering trust. Accordingly, as retailer, product, and website uncertainty are reduced, consumers rely on information cues to build trust, engage in information-seeking activities that reflect commitment, and form purchase intentions. Once these conditions are met, consumers move from the initial phase into the next phase of relationship development: the building phase.

The Building Phase

The building phase refers to the period during which consumers accumulate experience with the retailer through interactions and actual purchases. In this phase, consumers gain experience through interactions and investments of time, effort, and money that support continued exchange with the retailer in a high-uncertainty context. The primary goal of the phase is two-fold: (1) to continue reducing uncertainty, and (2) to build trust and commitment in order to encourage repurchase behavior and sustain relationship development.

Accordingly, the building phase begins when the consumer makes their first actual purchase from the retailer. Once the product is received, findings in this thesis (Papers I and IV) suggest that post-purchasing uncertainty

(related to post-purchase evaluation) emerges as consumers begin to evaluate their overall experience and assess whether the outcome meets their expectations. At the same time, uncertainty related to the retailer and product remains, as consumers still have limited experience and cannot yet fully assess reliability or product quality. In addition, purchasing uncertainty persists as future transactions continue to involve unknown outcomes. In other words, uncertainty does not immediately diminish in the early part of the building phase as consumers conduct their first purchase. This is because trust and commitment are not yet fully developed, as consumers remain relatively unfamiliar with the retailer and their experience is still limited.

Following the first actual purchase, consumers begin to evaluate multiple sources of uncertainty based on their first personal experiences (Paper I). These include the retailer itself, such as whether the retailer keeps its promises and acts in the consumer's best interest; the retailer's products, including whether the product matches expectations and descriptions (Pavlou et al., 2007; Mou et al., 2020b); and the retailer's website, such as whether it was efficient and easy to complete the purchase (Gefen et al., 2003; Cho and Sagynov, 2015; Taufique et al., 2024). The outcome of this initial evaluation determines how the building phase unfolds. If consumers perceive the first purchase experience as negative, for example, if the product does not meet expectations or delivery takes longer than promised, uncertainty remains heightened, and affective trust does not develop (Paper IV). In such cases, consumers are likely to terminate the building phase. In contrast, if consumers perceive the first purchase experience as positive, uncertainty diminishes, while trust and commitment begin to form through experience. Under these conditions, the building phase continues, and consumers develop repurchase intentions and eventually make actual repurchases (Paper IV).

Following the second, third, and subsequent purchases, consumers accumulate experience, and the building phase gradually matures. As a result of this repurchase behavior, the retailer, the product, purchasing, and post-purchasing uncertainty begin to decrease. Moreover, website uncertainty is less salient in this phase, as it has already been partially resolved during the initial interaction and purchase. Having navigated the website and completed a transaction, consumers no longer need to assess its usability or functionality. Instead, their attention shifts toward evaluating the outcomes of the purchase, making product, retailer, and post-purchasing uncertainties more salient. Based on the findings (Paper IV), trust gradually shifts from being primarily information-based to increasingly grounded in accumulated experiences, eventually taking on a more affective form. Commitment also begins to take a different form. As consumers perceive their repeated purchase experiences as satisfactory, early signs of deeper, stronger commitment emerge, such as initial recommendations. Commitment thus gradually moves beyond information-related activities, as consumers begin to invest effort by sharing their experiences and recommending the retailer to others. This pattern aligns with

the RET literature (Li et al., 2006; Wang et al., 2016; Nora, 2019; Antwi, 2021), which conceptualizes repurchase behavior as driven by trust and commitment. This pattern also holds in high-uncertainty contexts, where continued interactions and increasing confidence in the retailer support ongoing repurchasing and the accumulation of experience (Paper IV).

Based on the above, the relationship between trust and commitment in the building phase of relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts aligns with the traditional RET view, in which trust precedes commitment (Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Wang et al., 2016; Cui et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2023). However, while RET suggests that trust and commitment increase repurchase behavior (Nora, 2019; Antwi, 2021), it has largely treated these concepts as stable, without recognizing that they may take different forms and roles as the relationship develops. As a result, prior RET-based studies have not explicitly addressed how trust and commitment may change in nature as relationships develop, nor which forms of trust and commitment are most salient in driving repurchase behavior. In contrast, findings from the building phase in high-uncertainty contexts show that trust evolves from information-based to experience-based and eventually to affective-based, while commitment similarly shifts from information-oriented commitment to more active investments, such as recommending the retailer to others. In other words, these findings suggest that repurchase behavior depends not only on trust and commitment per se, but also on their evolving forms as the relationship develops (Paper IV).

In essence, the building phase serves as a preparatory period for the relationship phase, in which successful relationship development is not about eliminating uncertainty but about sustaining trust and commitment despite its continued presence. However, consumers remain in the building phase until two prerequisites are met. First, consumers must perceive that they gain value from continuing the relationship development and that this value cannot be obtained through alternative options. This value arises when the benefits of engaging with the retailer, such as satisfaction, convenience, or positive experiences, outweigh the associated costs, such as time and effort (Ravald and Grönroos, 1996). As a result, consumers become less likely to switch to alternative retailers (Li et al., 2006; Li et al., 2007; Lin et al., 2023). Second, uncertainty must be reduced to a point where past experiences allow consumers to reasonably anticipate how future purchases and post-purchase situations will unfold. This transition is particularly shaped by critical post-purchase moments, such as product defects, delivery issues, or other situations requiring customer support. When retailers respond responsibly, helpfully, and genuinely in these situations, consumers' confidence in the retailer is reinforced, and uncertainty about the retailer continues to diminish (Paper IV). Importantly, uncertainty about the retailer itself determines whether consumers transition into the relationship phase, as the relationship is formed with the retailer. While product uncertainty may still be present at this phase, it plays

a smaller role in influencing whether consumers move into the relationship phase. This is because, once uncertainty about the retailer is reduced, consumers trust that the retailer will accept returns or handle products appropriately if they do not meet expectations. This reasoning holds when positive, satisfactory experiences with both the overall journey and the products outweigh negative experiences. Accordingly, as trust and commitment continue to develop and uncertainty, particularly retailer uncertainty, is reduced, consumers become increasingly likely to enter the next phase of relationship development: the relationship phase.

The Relationship Phase

The relationship phase refers to the point at which the consumer's relationship with the retailer is established in a high-uncertainty context. The primary objective in this phase is to sustain long-term orientation by further strengthening the relationship. The behavioral purchasing outcome is consumers' actual repurchasing. Between repurchases, consumers evaluate their experiences (Paper I), and when these evaluations are positive, they strengthen trust and commitment (Paper IV), thereby reinforcing subsequent repurchasing. Consumers remain in this phase as long as they perceive value in maintaining interactions with the retailer.

Accordingly, much of the uncertainty that characterized earlier phases of relationship development is reduced through accumulated experience, a pattern also supported by prior RET research (Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Pavlou et al., 2007; Safari and Albaum, 2019). Website, purchasing, and post-purchasing uncertainties become less salient, as consumers understand how the website works, have made several purchases, and have experienced what happens after purchasing (Papers I and IV). As these types of uncertainties decline, some remain while others may emerge. In other words, the findings show that uncertainty does not disappear entirely (Paper IV).

Specifically, uncertainties related to the retailer and the product that were present in earlier phases of the relationship persist in latent form (Paper IV). This persistence can be explained by the fact that the consumer's relationship with the retailer is embedded within a broader network, in which retailers are connected to suppliers and other partners (Håkansson, 1982; Pels, 1999; Steinhoff et al., 2019). Consequently, changes within this network can affect the retailer and, in turn, the consumer relationship. For example, retailers may undergo organizational changes or face bankruptcy, and product quality may be affected if suppliers, materials, or production processes change (Ford and Mouzas, 2010; Schu and Morschett, 2017; Mueller and Swoboda, 2025). This was also evident in the findings, where some consumers experienced product deviations due to the retailer's manufacturer (Paper IV). Hence, although these

uncertainties are less salient, they do not disappear. Rather, they shift in form, becoming increasingly centered on the relationship itself.

Accordingly, the findings (Papers I and IV) show that, in the relationship phase, consumers encounter a distinct form of uncertainty: relationship uncertainty. Relationship uncertainty has been discussed in the marriage literature and refers to uncertainty about the relationship itself, particularly regarding its continuity and future outcomes (Knobloch, 2008). It arises because consumers face difficulties in anticipating the future of the relationship, which cannot be fully known or guaranteed (Papers I and IV). Consequently, even when experience reduces overall uncertainty, particularly regarding the retailer and the product, it does not fully disappear but remains inherent in the relationship, as relationship uncertainty persists in the ongoing interaction. Hence, consumers must cope with this uncertainty to sustain the relationship despite its continued presence. This challenges the suggestion in the RET literature that relationship development is primarily driven by the progressive reduction of uncertainty (Dwyer et al., 1987; Ford, 1980; Wilson, 1995; Pavlou et al., 2007). While this logic may hold in earlier phases, simply reducing uncertainty becomes insufficient once a relationship is established, as relationship uncertainty remains present in the consumer's ongoing relationship with the retailer. Therefore, sustaining the relationship depends on consumers' ability to cope with it.

One way consumers cope with uncertainty is through the mechanisms of trust and commitment. The findings show that this occurs through the reciprocal interplay between trust and commitment (Paper IV). In contrast to RET, which suggests that trust precedes commitment (Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007), trust and commitment no longer follow a unidirectional sequence in high-uncertainty contexts (Paper IV). Instead, they reinforce one another to manage uncertainty. This reciprocal pattern helps to shed light on ongoing theoretical debates within RET. Some scholars have questioned whether RET is complete and broadly applicable (Brown et al., 2019). This concern partly stems from prior studies reporting different patterns in the link between trust and commitment. Specifically, some findings suggest that trust affects commitment (e.g., Eastlick et al., 2006; Wang et al., 2016; Cui et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2023), while others indicate the opposite, namely that commitment affects trust (e.g., Bilgihan and Bujisic, 2015). Although these findings may appear conflicting, the results of this thesis suggest that, in the relationship phase, trust and commitment influence each other rather than following a single direction. However, in the initial phase of relationship development, they tend to follow a single directional pattern. In this respect, this thesis provides an indication and a possible explanation for these differing findings in prior work. Specifically, the relationship between trust and commitment may vary across the different phases of relationship development because of the role of uncertainty throughout this development.

As the relationship phase matures, consumer switching becomes less likely as trust and commitment deepen. Prior RET studies show that high switching costs further reduce the likelihood of relationship termination (Li et al., 2007; Lin et al., 2023). Findings from this thesis (Paper IV) reflect that this is especially true in high-uncertainty contexts, as ending the relationship would require consumers to restart the relationship development from the very beginning, engage in extensive information search, and face heightened uncertainty once again. Such efforts are particularly demanding in high-uncertainty contexts, where uncertainty is present from the outset and relationship formation requires substantial investments in search and deliberation (Safari and Yamin, 2016). For that reason, the investments already made encourage consumers to continue the relationship rather than initiate a new one under similar conditions of uncertainty. Moreover, consumers remain in the relationship when they perceive no alternatives offering greater value. As trust and commitment persist and strengthen, they enable consumers to cope with uncertainty and reinforce their decision to continue the relationship in high-uncertainty contexts.

6. Conclusion

Theoretical Implications

Since its introduction in the marketing literature in the 1980s, RET was initially developed to explain relationship development in B2B markets (Håkanson, 1982; Dwyer et al., 1987; Ford, 1980; Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Wilson, 1995) and was later extended to B2C markets (Gruen, 1995; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; De Wulf et al., 2001; Bhattacharya and Sen, 2003; Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Zhang et al., 2016; Connors et al., 2021), albeit not without criticism (Barnes, 1994; O'Malley and Tynan, 2000; O'Malley, 2001; Leahy, 2011; Safari and Albaum, 2019). Despite this extension, RET has predominantly been developed and applied in low-uncertainty contexts. Consequently, four decades of accumulated theoretical knowledge on relationship development are mostly grounded primarily under conditions of low uncertainty. This emphasis is partly explained by the notion that studying consumer relationships has long been considered a theoretically and empirically challenging endeavor (Gruen, 1995; Safari and Albaum, 2019) and has historically been debated in terms of their very existence (Barnes, 1994; O'Malley and Tynan, 2000; O'Malley, 2001; Leahy, 2011). Hence, research has predominantly focused on low-uncertainty contexts, while high-uncertainty contexts have remained underexplored due to the additional complexity they entail. In contrast, this thesis departs from this longstanding tradition by moving beyond low-uncertainty contexts to examine consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts. As a result, this thesis offers several notable theoretical implications.

First, beyond extending RET to high-uncertainty contexts, this thesis takes a further step by developing a conceptual model of consumer relationship development in such contexts (Figure 1). Prior research has proposed several models of relationship development; however, these have predominantly focused on B2B relationships (e.g., Ford, 1980; Dwyer et al., 1987; Morgan and Hunt, 1994), and even in the few examples examining B2C relationships (e.g., Fournier, 1998; Wang et al., 2000; Campbell et al., 2009), knowledge about consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts has remained absent. Therefore, this thesis not only adds new insights into consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts but also contributes a novel conceptual model to explain such development.

Second, this thesis contributes to an increased understanding of uncertainty typologies in high-uncertainty contexts. It specifically increases knowledge of the additional types of uncertainty that affect consumer relationship development. Previous studies have typically treated uncertainty as a background condition or a single, unidimensional concept (Gruen, 1995; Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Lin et al., 2023), with only a few acknowledging that it may originate from multiple sources (e.g., Pavlou et al., 2007; Mou et al., 2020b). Nevertheless, much of the existing theoretical knowledge has been grounded in low-uncertainty contexts, where overall uncertainty is lower and typologies are fewer. Accordingly, this thesis offers a theoretical refinement of RET's existing understanding of the role of uncertainty. In contrast to the traditional view of RET, which suggests that uncertainty decreases as relationships develop (Ford, 1980; Dwyer et al., 1987; Morgan and Hunt, 1994; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Lin et al., 2023), this thesis shows that uncertainty is not only reduced but also coped with. Specifically, the initial phase is characterized by multiple salient uncertainty typologies, resulting in high overall uncertainty (Figure 1). As the relationship develops, fewer typologies remain salient, and uncertainty becomes less prominent, but it does not disappear; relationship uncertainty remains. Accordingly, the way uncertainty is managed shifts from reduction to ongoing coping, through the interplay of both trust and commitment. While uncertainty must be reduced to initiate and build the relationship, sustaining it in the relationship phase requires ongoing coping. Uncertainty is thus inherent in the consumer relationship with the retailer, and consumers must cope with it to sustain this relationship over the long term.

Third, this thesis explains how consumer relationships develop in high-uncertainty contexts. It specifically shows that relationships progress through three phases: initial, building, and relationship, each characterized by distinct roles of uncertainty, trust, and commitment. In contrast to prior RET-based research, which has largely treated these concepts without detailing their development, this thesis shows that uncertainty, trust, and commitment are fluid. They take different forms and influence one another in distinct ways across the phases of relationship development. This provides a deeper explanation of relationship development, showing not only that these concepts evolve, but also how and when they evolve and shape the relationship. Building on this, this thesis shows that relationship development under high uncertainty departs from RET's traditional conceptualization regarding the ordering of these concepts. Whereas RET-based studies consistently posit that trust precedes commitment in the initial phase (Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007), this thesis shows that under high uncertainty, the opposite ordering holds: early commitment efforts precede and foster trust. As relationships progress into the building phase and uncertainty decreases, the direction of influence aligns with established RET logic: trust increasingly strengthens commitment as it becomes grounded in accumulated experience. In the relationship phase,

uncertainty persists in reduced and altered forms, and trust and commitment become closely intertwined. When they interact jointly, uncertainty shifts from being addressed through reduction to ongoing coping, enabling the sustained development of the relationship.

Returning to the point raised in the introduction that "the purpose of theories is to increase scientific understanding by explaining and predicting phenomena" (Hunt, 2011, p. 76), the three theoretical implications identified in this thesis raise an important question: what do they imply for one of the marketing discipline's foundational theories, RET? The short answer is that these implications do not falsify RET; rather, they prompt a reconsideration of its core theoretical conditions and the traditional view of how relationships develop. The long answer, however, is that RET remains a robust and relevant theory for understanding consumer relationship development, but its foundational framing requires refinement, not only when applied in B2C markets but also in high-uncertainty contexts. This thesis shows that, in its current form, RET offers limited explanatory and predictive insight into relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts. Rather than concluding here, the thesis advances RET by introducing a conceptual framework that refines its core concepts and enhances its ability to explain and predict relationship development in contexts of heightened uncertainty.

Accordingly, this contribution is particularly essential given that prior research has historically been divided on the applicability of RET in B2C markets. While some studies have questioned its applicability (e.g., Barnes, 1994; O'Malley, 2001; Leahy, 2011), others have argued that consumer relationships do exist and that RET is applicable in B2C contexts (e.g., Bagozzi, 1995; Gruen, 1995; Peterson, 1995; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Fournier, 1998; Garbarino and Johnson, 1999; Pels, 1999; Safari, 2014; Connors et al., 2021; Berg, 2022; Iveson et al., 2026). In line with the latter view, this thesis shows that RET is applicable in B2C markets, even under heightened uncertainty; however, it requires theoretical refinement to fully capture such contexts. Specifically, RET's core concepts of uncertainty, trust, and commitment are more fluid and phase-contingent than previously recognized. Relationship development under high uncertainty unfolds through a shifting interplay among these concepts, shaped by the magnitude of uncertainty. In this regard, uncertainty is not only reduced (Ford, 1980; Dwyer et al., 1987; Sheth and Parvatiyar, 1995; Pavlou et al., 2007; Safari and Thilenius, 2013) but is also coped with. Trust does not uniformly precede commitment (Eastlick et al., 2006; Mukherjee and Nath, 2007; Cui et al., 2020; Lin et al., 2023) under conditions of heightened uncertainty; commitment may instead function as an antecedent to trust. Based on the above, this thesis not only contributes to the longstanding debate regarding the applicability of RET in B2C markets but also offers theoretical refinements that extend RET beyond low-uncertainty contexts, enhancing its ability to explain consumer relationship development in high-uncertainty contexts.

Managerial Implications

This thesis offers several managerial implications for retailers operating in high-uncertainty contexts, particularly POI-retailers in CBEC. The findings show that consumer relationship development under heightened uncertainty does not follow the typical paths suggested by prior research. Instead, the roles of uncertainty, trust, and commitment shift across the different phases of relationship development. Understanding how trust, commitment, and uncertainty vary across phases enables managers and CEOs of POI-retailers to design more effective strategies for attracting, developing, and sustaining consumer relationships in high-uncertainty contexts. Accordingly, managers should adopt phase-specific strategies rather than relying on standardized approaches that overlook differences across relationship phases.

In the initial phase, consumers face high levels of uncertainty and lack prior experience with the retailer. The findings show that, at this point, commitment primarily takes the form of information-related activities. For managers implementing a POI strategy in CBEC, this means that, in the initial phase, they should prioritize reducing key uncertainties about the website, the retailer, and the product. Website uncertainty can be reduced by ensuring the website is easy to use, useful, and reliable, as this helps consumers navigate the purchase process efficiently and access the information they need. Similarly, retailer uncertainty can be reduced by providing clear company information, relevant certifications, and trustworthy third-party endorsements that enhance the retailer's trustworthiness. Product uncertainty can be addressed through detailed descriptions, images, and reviews. By reducing these uncertainties, managers can support consumers' commitment to information search, enable the formation of information-based trust, and encourage further progress in relationship development.

As consumers enter the building phase and make their first purchase, accumulated experiences help reduce several types of uncertainty. In this phase, trust becomes increasingly experience-based, and repeated interactions play a central role in shaping consumers' evaluations. Importantly, while website, retailer, and product uncertainty decrease with use and experience, post-purchase uncertainty becomes particularly important to address, as consumers evaluate whether outcomes meet their expectations after the purchase is complete. In this regard, it is important for POI-retailers to provide transparent order confirmations, tracking information, and proactive updates about delivery status. All of these signals from the retailer can help consumers understand what to expect and when. Clear, easily accessible return, refund, and complaint-handling procedures are also essential, as they reduce uncertainty about how problems will be addressed if outcomes fall short of expectations. In addition, responsive customer service that addresses questions or issues promptly reassures consumers and reinforces trust in the retailer. By managing post-purchase interactions in a predictable and supportive manner, POI-

retailers can reduce post-purchase uncertainty and strengthen experience-based trust, thereby supporting the continued development of consumer relationships. Therefore, ensuring product quality, trackable delivery, and effective post-purchase support is essential, not only after the first purchase but also after each purchase. This consistency creates satisfactory experiences, increasing the likelihood that consumers progress into the relationship phase.

In the relationship phase, the findings show that uncertainty does not disappear; instead, it takes the form of relationship uncertainty. This form of uncertainty cannot be fully reduced; instead, it depends on consumers' ability to cope with it. To facilitate uncertainty coping, POI-retailer managers should focus on reinforcing trust and commitment through consistent actions and sustained efforts over the long term. Actions that signal a long-term orientation include stable, easy-to-follow return procedures, helpful customer support, and smooth complaint-handling processes. Such stability and consistency help consumers perceive the relationship as reliable, even when future outcomes cannot be predicted. As trust and commitment strengthen, consumers are less likely to switch retailers and more likely to recommend the retailer to others. Managers should therefore remain committed and responsive during unexpected events, as doing so reinforces consumer trust and commitment and supports retention and positive word of mouth, despite ongoing uncertainty.

Limitations and Future Research

This thesis makes several contributions; however, it is not without limitations. These limitations also highlight important opportunities for future research. First, this thesis has focused on a specific type of high-uncertainty context, namely, POI-retailers in CBEC. While this focus enables theoretical insight into consumer relationship development under heightened uncertainty, it also limits the generalizability of the findings. The phase-specific roles of uncertainty, trust, and commitment identified in this thesis may not unfold in the same way in contexts with lower uncertainty or in contexts where uncertainty takes a different form. Future research is therefore recommended to examine whether the proposed phase-based dynamics apply in other high-uncertainty contexts. In addition, comparative studies across low- and high-uncertainty contexts would be particularly relevant. Such research could further clarify how uncertainty shapes relationship development and whether similar relational mechanisms operate under different contextual conditions. This would further enrich the debate on the application of RET in B2C markets.

Second, this thesis is based on empirical data collected from Swedish consumers. In this regard, future research could replicate these findings in other national contexts to assess whether the identified relationship phases and uncertainty dynamics hold across countries. Cross-national comparisons could

also help identify which aspects of consumer relationship development are context-specific and which are more generalizable.

Third, the empirical studies primarily examine consumer relationship development from the consumer's perspective. While this approach aligns with the focus of the thesis, it does not include the retailer's perspective. Future research could adopt dyadic designs that incorporate both consumer and retailer perspectives to provide a more complete understanding of relationship development under uncertainty. Such approaches would be particularly valuable for understanding the practical constraints retailers face when attempting to reduce consumer uncertainty and support relationship development on their side.

Finally, the conceptual framework proposed in this thesis was developed and examined within a specific high-uncertainty context. Although the framework extends existing RET-based research by showing that uncertainty, trust, and commitment play different roles and take different forms across relationship development phases, it remains empirically grounded in a specific empirical context. Future research is needed to test the proposed conceptual framework in other high- and low-uncertainty contexts to assess its robustness and broader applicability.

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DOCTORAL THESES

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